

The Hearth Ledger

Tales of the Threshold

Told by the fires of Fate's Edge

Set down by *Dusana of the Raven Road*

Under the lamp, bread and salt. The ink is ash and rain.

Contents

1	The Vent That Whispered	1
2	The Hollow Bride	9
3	The Warrior Who Refused to Call the Runner	17
4	The Silk Witness	25
5	The Gloss That Ate a Name	31
6	The Bargain of the Shed Skin	37
7	The Selkie's Oath	43
8	The Peddler's Swerve	49
9	The Censor's Mask	55
10	The Bride of Nine Knots	61
11	The Bride of Nine Knots	67
12	The Stair That Was Not	75
13	The Lantern That Remembered	85

14	The Bell That Never Rang	95
15	The Loom of Witness	103
16	The Coin That Came Back	111
17	The Veil and the Cradle	119
18	The Ford That Moved	127
19	The Fog Road	135
20	The Counting of the Fifth Breath	143
21	The Saffron Gate	151
22	The Grain That Spoke	159
23	The Bargain of the Unlit Lamp	167
24	The Soup That Was Free	177

Preface: The Road That Listens

A story is not a reckoning. It balances nothing. But it warms the hands.

You travel. You sit by fires. A woman speaks. You write. The ash on your cuff becomes ink. That is all. That is enough.

My people are the Tulkani. We build no temples. Our wagons carry the hearth. Kuva rides the storm—some say. I have lit a candle for him when the road was ice and the horses would not move. Kuva counts the stars. I count the thresholds.

Ikasha does not command. She sleeps. Between her breaths there is room for secrets. I have borrowed that space. I will return it when I am done. She does not ask for interest.

These tales were told by midwives, bell-wardens, hedge-mothers, cord-weavers. They did not call themselves witches. The women who speak to the dead never do. The dead have enough names already.

I wrote as the fire guttered. Where a teller coughed, I left a space. Where a bell rang, I marked the hour. Where the ninth word was missing—I did not add it. The ninth word belongs to the threshold. The threshold was not

speaking that night.

Some tales are comfort. Some are warnings. A few are keys. The lock is not in this book. The lock is in the reader's chest. Turn the key gently. It may be older than you think.

Read them. Or do not. The road turns regardless. The hearth waits. The stories will be here when you come back. They have nowhere else to go.

— *Dusana of the Raven Road*

*Under the lamp, bread and salt. The ink is ash and rain.
The rain has stopped. The ash is still warm.*

I The Vent That Whispered

Told by

Old Orra, lamp-keeper of the Third Stack, Aelerian Range. Not been underground in thirty years, but still counts her breaths before sleep. She told this tale in the dark. Would not light a candle.

The Tale

You ever walk the Deep Galleries alone? No. Good. Don't start.

The air down there has a measure. Eight breaths is a corridor. Sixteen is a chamber. Thirty-two is a fool who forgot to turn back. That's what they taught me. Breathe, count, turn. Never answer the ninth.

I was young. Lamp trimmed, chalk dry. Third Stack to the old sump. Easy walk. Should've been two hours.

At the junction — you know the one, three tunnels, the middle one always drips — I stopped. Something was wrong. The drip had stopped. The echo had changed. The stone felt soft under my boot. And then I heard it.

Not with my ears. Inside. Like a memory that wasn't mine. Like someone else's grief pressed into my skull like

a thumb into clay.

“Count the ninth breath.”

I didn’t. I walked faster. The voice followed.

“The ninth holds the name of the miner who died here. The year the pillar cracked. The route to the lost sump. The name of the man who forgot to turn back.”

My lamp flickered. The flame burned blue for a heart-beat. I didn’t stop to trim it. I kept counting. Eight in. Eight out. My lips moved. The voice couldn’t find the crack.

When I reached the surface, the lamp was dry. My shadow was gone. The sun was setting and I cast nothing. The other miners stared. They did not ask.

The next morning I looked in a mirror — a real one, polished brass, not a still puddle — and the reflection smiled first.

Took a week for the shadow to come back. Took another for my left hand to stop writing in a script I couldn’t read. The Vent-Prior said the deep had spoken and I hadn’t answered, and that was mercy. She said the mountain respects the ones who know where the door is.

She promoted me to lamp-keeper. I never went down again. I tend the wicks. I count the hours. I do not breathe in rhythm.

The Witch's Closing

“Stone remembers. So does the space between breaths. Answer neither. And if you must walk the deep, count to eight — then start over. The ninth is not for you.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Voice in the Crack

Description: A psychic remnant of a Deep Drake sealed in the mountain. It cannot move, but it whispers into the minds of those who walk alone in deep, dark, air-starved places. It offers secrets like a miser offers silver. It asks for the ninth breath — the one you were not meant to take.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [PSIONIC] [DOMAIN (stone)] [DREAD]
- Harm: none directly — mental strain.
- Fatigue: On failed Spirit + Resolve (DV 4), mark 1 Fatigue and hear a false memory so vivid it feels true for a heartbeat.
- Timer : *Counting the Ninth* [4] — ticks each time a character answers a question while alone in the

dark. When full, the character's shadow detaches for 1d3 days. During this time, social Position worsens by one step (people feel something missing), and the shadow may act independently — watching, pointing, once opening a door the character meant to keep shut.

- **Strings:** The Voice can offer a *True Shem* — a forgotten fact, a lost name, a route through stone that the maps erased — in exchange for counting the ninth breath (advancing the timer by one segment). The secret is always true. The price is always the same.

Motivation: Feeds on attention and isolation. Wants to be witnessed. Does not hate the living. Does not love them either. It is lonely. That is worse.

Adventure Hook: A vent-warden has gone missing in the Third Stack. The party finds a crack in the wall — and hears breathing on the other side. Slow. Measured. Counting.

Colophon

Recorded in the Third Stack hostel, winter of 862, by
Dusana of the Raven Road. The chalk circle was erased
before I slept. My shadow arrived a heartbeat late. I did
not ask where it had been.

The ink is soot and melted wax. The lamp is borrowed.

A Note on the Telling

The Aeler woman erased the circle with her palm. "Now the forgetting begins," she said.

I wrote quickly. The chalk dust tasted of lime.

– *Third Stack hostel, year of the long winter.*

2 The Hollow Bride

Told by

Mabs the Miller, a round woman with flour on her apron and a cider-cup always half full. Tells stories while she works the grindstone. Says the Hollow talks to her at night. Would not say what it says.

The Tale

You know about the ninth cup, don't you? Course you do. Every child knows: you pour eight. You never pour the ninth. The ninth is for the Hollow.

But children forget. Or they get curious. Or they think the rules are for other people, the ones who didn't grow up in a house with a red door and a mother who counted every breath. That's how it always starts.

Little Kesta — she was what, seven? eight? — went to the well at dusk. The adults were at the harvest feast, the kind where the ale flows and the children run wild and no one watches the threshold. She was supposed to draw water for the morning bread. Simple work. She'd done it a hundred times.

She counted the buckets. One, two, three, four, five,

six, seven, eight.

She pulled them up. She set them in a row. The water was clear. The moon was not yet up. The well was just a well.

Then she thought: what's one more? Just to see.

She drew the ninth bucket. The rope was cold. The water was black. Not dark — black. Like someone had poured ink into the deep and stirred it with a bone. And something climbed out.

It wore her mother's wedding dress, the one that hung in the cedar chest, the one no one had touched since the plague year. It smiled with her mother's mouth, the way her mother smiled when she was tired and pretending not to be. But its eyes were the color of a drowned moon. Gray. Swollen. Watching.

"Hollow Bride," Kesta whispered. That's what the old folk call it. You don't name it. You don't speak its name. You don't give it that kind of hold. She named it.

The Bride followed her home. Walked three paces behind, silent as a held breath. Stood outside the red door. Knocked.

Three knocks. Then a pause. Then three more. The rhythm of a heart that stopped. The rhythm of someone counting to eight and then waiting.

Kesta's mother opened the door. She saw the dress. She saw the mouth. She did not see the eyes — she looked

at the threshold, not the face. "Come in," she said. "You must be cold." That's the law of hospitality. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night. You cannot refuse. The door remembers.

The Hollow Bride stepped inside. It sat at the table. It didn't eat. It didn't drink. It didn't speak. It just watched. Watched Kesta braid her hair. Watched the mother bank the fire. Watched the father pretend not to see.

At midnight, it spoke. Its voice was the sound of water dripping in a well that had gone dry.

"You poured the ninth cup. You named me. Now I am your guest."

The mother understood then. She cut a loaf with a knife that had been blessed at the Moot Oak, the kind of knife that costs three silver and a whispered prayer. She put salt on the table with her left hand, palm up, the way the hedge-witch taught her. She said: "Guest-right lasts one night. At dawn, you leave."

The Hollow Bride smiled. It was the mother's smile. It was wrong.

"I will leave," it said. "But I will return. The ninth cup is an invitation. The threshold remembers. The red door remembers. And I have a long memory for small slights."

Kesta is an old woman now. She still sets eight cups on her table. She still leaves the ninth empty. She still checks

the red door at dusk and again at dawn. And every harvest, when the lanterns burn blue at the ford and the sheep will not cross the bridge, she walks the perimeter and touches every stone.

So far, it's held. So far, the Bride has not returned.

But the miller says the well water tasted of salt last spring. And the sheep won't drink.

The Witch's Closing

"Hospitality is a thread. Tie it right, and it binds the guest. Tie it wrong, and it binds you. The thread does not fray on its own. Someone cuts it. And never, ever pour the ninth. Not even to see what happens. Because something always does."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hollow Bride

Description: A threshold-spirit that wears the face of a loved one. It can only enter a home if invited — either by name, by pouring a ninth cup, by drawing a ninth bucket, or by breaking any taboo that counts to eight and then pauses. It does not hate the living. It is hungry for something else. Recognition, perhaps. Or the sound of a

door opening when it should stay shut.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [FAE] [THRESHOLD] [DREAD]
- Cannot cross a red door unless invited. Repelled by bread, salt, and a knife blessed at a moot or cross-roads.
- Harm: none directly. It imposes Conditions. *Watched* (someone is looking at you from the corner of every room). *Invited* (you spoke its name or poured the ninth — it will remember). *Named* (you gave it a name it did not ask for. Names have weight).
- Timer : *The Ninth Cup* [6] — ticks each time hospitality is broken: a door left unlatched, a guest refused bread, a ninth cup poured. When full, the Bride can enter any home in the village. Does not need to knock first.
- Bargaining: The Bride may be offered a substitute — a memory, a name, a firstborn child, the silence of a particular witness — to buy another year. The substitute must be offered freely. The Bride does not take. It accepts.

Motivation: To be invited. To be remembered. To stand outside a red door and hear it open from the inside. It is not cruel. It is patient. That is worse.

Adventure Hook: A village has the same nightmare: a woman in a wedding dress outside a red door, knocking. Three knocks. Then a pause. Then three more. The sheep are dying. The well tastes of salt. The party must find who broke guest-right and heal the threshold before the ninth cup is poured again.

Colophon

Recorded in the miller's kitchen, year of the sour harvest. The kettle was warm. The cider was dry. The Bride did not knock that night. The miller put an extra log on the fire anyway. Said she could feel something standing in the yard, watching the window. I did not look.

The ink is lampblack and rain. The ninth cup remains on the shelf.

The Empty Cup

Eight cups. Eight names. The ninth cup missing.

"Count," the Aelaerem witch said. "If the ninth is not there, it is not owed."

She drank from the eighth. The lamp guttered. No ninth.

– *Meadow south of the Valewood, moon forgetting its phase.*

3 The Warrior Who Refused to Call the Runner

Told by

Temur Many-Scars, steppe rider with a braid down to his belt and a laugh like breaking bones. Been in more camps than he can count. Says the only thing that kept him alive was bad geometry. He taught me the kon'reh that night. I lost every match.

A Note on the Telling

The Ykrul speak of the board with their own tongue. I have written the Ykrul words in *italics* where they first appear, then given the common term. The kon'reh is forced into the telling because the Ykrul do not separate war from the game that teaches war. You cannot understand one without the other. Temur made this clear. He was polite about it. Politeness on the steppe means you are being taught something. Rudeness means you are being measured.

<i>War-Chief</i>	the piece others call Blue
<i>Runner</i>	Green
<i>Well</i>	Sanctum
<i>Calling a Runner</i>	Seeding
<i>Nailed</i>	Rooted
<i>The Five-Breath Race</i>	Reforge
<i>Cuts</i>	specials
<i>Breaths</i>	plies
<i>The shadow of the stone</i>	Zone of Control (ZoC)

The Tale

The Khagan called a muster. We were young, hungry, and stupid. The kind of stupid that gets carved into the clan archive as a lesson for grandchildren. My cousin — bold as a winter wolf, twice as fast, half as patient — wanted glory. He pushed his *War-Chief* forward across the board. He didn't count exits. He just pushed.

The enemy stepped aside. Let him pass. Let him think he was winning. That's the oldest trick on the steppe. Give a fool enough rope and he'll hang himself. Give a warrior enough board and he'll forget the Well.

By the time he reached the *Well*, his *cut* was spent. He looked at the far *Well*. It was empty. He could *Call a Runner*. But his *War-Chief* would be *Nailed* for a *breath*. Rooted. Fixed. A target the size of a tent flap.

I said: “Don’t. Their *War-Chief* still has a *cut*. They’re two *breaths* away from boxing you in. Count the shadow before you move.”

He laughed. “They won’t risk it. They’re cowards. Look at them. They haven’t moved in three beats.”

He *Called*.

The enemy hopped a stone — just one, the smallest move on the board, the kind you learn on your first day and forget by your second — landed on the *Well*, and *displaced* his *War-Chief* off the board. The *Five-Breath Race* started ticking. Five beats. That’s all my cousin had. Plant his banner in five *breaths* or lose the match and the tribute and the clan’s good opinion.

He didn’t. He couldn’t. The enemy had already welded the approach. Every lane ended in *the shadow of the stone*. The race was dead before it started. The banner never touched ground.

We lost. The clan paid tribute for a year. Silver. Horses. Three strings of good beads that my grandmother had woven. The Khagan made us watch as she handed them over.

The Khagan demoted him to herd-watcher. She took his braid. She took his seat at the fire. She said: “You forgot the first number. Not the second, not the third. The first. Count exits before you count glory. Call only when the geometry is yours. The board does not forgive. Neither do I.”

My cousin watched the sheep for three winters. He learned to count. He never played kon'reh again.

The Witch's Closing

"A free *War-Chief* is a noose waiting for a neck. *Call* only when the shadow is yours. Always keep one *cut* for the door. The board is patient. It will wait for you to forget."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Herd-Watcher's Regret (a curse)

Description: A punishment that falls on warriors who *Call* unsafely — who move without counting exits, who trust luck over geometry. The curse does not strike the body. It strikes the name. Reputation frays. Rank dissolves. Direction fails at the worst moment. The victim becomes forgettable. Still alive. Still breathing. Still eating and sleeping and walking the camp. But no longer counted.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [CURSE] [SOCIAL] [DREAD]
- Effect: -1 Position on all Command and Sway rolls. People listen but do not hear.

- Once per session, the GM may force a re-roll on any Navigation or Tactics check. The character remembers the wrong path. The short cut leads to a ravine. The ambush point is already occupied.
- Strings: The curse can be lifted by a public act of heroic geometry — winning a kon'reh match against a worthy opponent, or completing a Five-Breath Race under the old rules. No one can help. The geometry must be yours.
- Timer : *Forgotten Name* [6] — ticks each time the character gives an order that is ignored, or each time someone looks past them to address someone else. When full, the character loses their name entirely. No one remembers them. Not their mother. Not their khagan. Not the enemy they once defeated. They become a stranger at their own fire.

Motivation: The curse is not sentient. It is a habit of the steppe, a pattern carved into the bone of the Ykrul by ten thousand kon'reh matches. The board remembers what the players forget. It enforces its own geometry.

Adventure Hook: A decorated warrior has disappeared from the camp archive. Not physically. She still sits by the fire. She still eats her share of the meat. But everyone

looks past her. The khagan's scribe cannot recall her name. The clan's children do not know her face. The party must restore her name — or watch her fade into the shadow of the stone.

Colophon

Winter camp of the Gray Fox clan, somewhere between the salt flats and the frozen river. The rider spat tea leaves into the fire and said: "That was the winter I learned to count. The sheep were better company than the board." He taught me three openings and one closing. I remember the closing.

The ink is tea and ash. The board is still on the table.

The Count

The Ykrul woman held up eight fingers. Then one fist.

"Nine is not a number," she said. "It is a wound that hasn't closed."

– *Winter camp, Gray Fox clan, year the passes froze.*

4 The Silk Witness

Told by

Maer of the Root-Circle, a graying wood elf who mends bridges and remembers every broken oath. Speaks like water over stones — soft, but sharp. Her hands never stop moving. Mending, knotting, untangling.

The Tale

A merchant came to the Valewood, full of himself and his archives. He needed a bridge. He had coin. He did not have courtesy.

He spoke to the Lethai-al wardens. "Name your price," he said. "Double if you build it by autumn."

They sent for the Silk Vigil. The Vigil hung a thread across the river. White silk, thin as a spider's. "Cross this," they said, "and we will talk."

The merchant laughed and stepped over.

The thread broke.

The Vigil nodded. "You have refused witness. Build your bridge. Every plank will remember your rudeness. No one will sing its name. No child will skip across it. No lover will meet at its center."

He built it. It held. Stone and good timber. No curse in the mortar. But the workers called it "the Rudeness." Travelers spat on its railings. Mothers pulled their children to the other bank.

Years later, he returned, bent and gray. The bridge had not fallen. It had not forgiven either. He knelt at the Vigil's threshold. "What must I pay?"

The Vigil picked up a single strand of silk from the dust. Held it to the light. "Say this: 'I am sorry for the courtesy I broke.' Say it once, and mean it. Then build a garden under the bridge, for the eels to hide in. Soft places. Mud. Roots. Let the water slow."

He did. He knelt in the mud himself, planting rushes. The eels came. The bridge softened. The moss grew over the stone where men had spat.

Now they sing of it — not as a curse, but as a repair. Travelers leave a thread tied to the rail. One strand. White. Thin.

The Witch's Closing

"Mercy with memory. That is the thread. Cut it, and you build alone. Heal it, and the road belongs to everyone. The eels remember both."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Unwitnessed Bridge

A bridge built without proper rites — no thread, no witness, no offering of courtesy. Sound as stone, sound as timber. But it radiates a low social curse, thin as a spider's silk, easy to ignore until you feel it in your teeth.

Those who cross feel irritation, suspicion, the sense that someone spoke behind their back and stopped when they turned.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [CURSE] [LOCATION] [SOCIAL]
- –I Position on social rolls while on or near the bridge.
- Once per day, the GM may force a reroll on any Command or Sway roll attempted while crossing. Take the lower result.
- Timer : *Repair the Bridge* [6] — ticks when someone crosses without courtesy, or when the bridge is used for argument or threat. Needs an offering of courtesy (bread, salt, a spoken apology) and a public act of repair — planting, cleaning, mending a cracked rail. Each full segment cleared requires one such act, witnessed by at least three people.

Adventure Hook: A new bridge divides a river community. Merchants whisper of bad luck. Bargains struck on the bridge sour within a week. Lovers quarrel at the midpoint and do not know why. The builder died rich, unrepentant, and left no heir. The bridge needs healing. The question is who will kneel in the mud.

Colophon

Sat under a roof-tree at the edge of the Root-Circle. The eels were listening. I left a thread.

The ink is river water and crushed rush. The candle is borrowed.

The Thread

The Lethai-al woman held up a strand of silk. "This is a promise," she said. "It breaks when you lie."

At the end of the story, it was still whole.

– *Root-Circle, autumn equinox.*

5 The Gloss That Ate a Name

Told by

Archivist Velynnne, a Lethai with ink under her nails and a voice that never rises above a murmur. Says she has forgotten more languages than most people learn. Her ears are pierced with copper rings. She would not tell me what they commemorated.

The Tale

In the great library of Thepyrgos — the Lethai do not call it a library, they call it the Still-Room, where words go to be forgotten properly — there is a scroll that rewrites itself. Copied from a copy from a copy, each margin a correction, each correction a new error. The Lethai keep it because they keep everything. Even hunger.

A scholar — call her Miralis, though that was not her first name and not her last — wanted the original. The Still-Room keepers refused. "The original is not lost," they said. "It is eating. We do not feed it."

Miralis found the forbidden room anyway. Lethai doors do not lock. They wait. Inside, a single scroll sealed with wax the color of old bruises. She broke the seal.

The scroll was blank. She turned it over. Blank. She held it to the lamp. Blank.

Weeks passed. Miralis began to forget the taste of rain. Her students' faces blurred into the same pale oval. Her mother's voice became a hum, then a frequency, then nothing. She returned to the Still-Room. The scroll now held one word, written in her own hand though she had never touched a brush:

Miralis.

She understood then, the way the Lethai understand hunger: slowly, then all at once. The scroll did not store knowledge. It *ate* it. The copies were not safety. They were rations. The original was the mouth.

She burned it with a lamp she had carried since childhood — a brass thing, dented, warm. The fire was cold. The smoke smelled of a birthday she could no longer describe. Her name came back in pieces. Her grandmother's face stayed gone. That was the toll the Still-Room keepers had tried to warn her about.

They did not say *I told you so*. Lethai do not. They poured her tea and watched her drink. The tea had no taste. She could not remember if it ever had.

The Witch's Closing

“Context is a key. Lose the key, lose the door. Lose the door, you are still in the room. The room does not mind. The room is patient.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hungry Scroll

An ancient Lethai artifact that erases memory. Appears as a blank parchment in a sealed case. The Lethai do not destroy such things. They shelve them. The shelves have no labels.

Tags / Mechanics:

- Tags: [CURSE] [KNOWLEDGE] [DREAD]
- On reading, test Spirit + Resolve (DV 5). Failure: lose one memory (player chooses a minor fact — the name of a tavern, a route home, the sound of a friend's laugh).
- Timer : *Erasure* [8]. When full, victim forgets their own name and cannot form new long-term memories. They become a Still-Room keeper. The job has no shortage of applicants.

- Destroyed only with fire from a living witness (a bell, a lamp, a human breath) — and the witness must speak the victim’s true name while the paper burns. Lethai consider this rude. They do not say why.

Adventure Hook: A Lethai scholar has gone missing. Her notes are contradictions. In her study, a blank scroll on a lectern. The lamp is still warm. Read it, burn it, or seal it — knowing someone else will find it. Knowing the Still-Room has a space on the shelf.

Colophon

Copied from a margin note in a book that was not supposed to leave Thepyrgos. The archivist would not let me see her face. The ink was still wet. She said, *“Take it. I have forgotten why I kept it.”*

The paper is birch. The lamp flickers. The name Miralis is a placeholder.

The Blank Page

The high elf pointed to a page in her archive. "This is where the name was," she said.

The paper was smooth. No erasure. Just a space.

– *Thepyrgos, scriptorium at midnight.*

6 The Bargain of the Shed Skin

Told by

Serpent-keeper Ashai, a dark elf with scales tattooed up her forearms and a voice like a knife wrapped in silk — soft until it is not. She has shed three names already. She remembers the first two.

The Tale

A woman came to the Coil Court. She stood in the threshold, one boot on each side. "I gave a Lethaiar my fear of the dark. Now I cannot sleep. The faces in the shadows are not mine."

The serpent-queen did not look up from her coils. "You paid for a shedding. You received it. The price was never your fear. The price was your solitude."

The woman wept — a dry, rattling sound. "I did not know."

"You did not ask. The Coil Court does not sell answers. It sells skins."

The woman was quiet for a long breath. Then she offered a second bargain. "Shed this solitude. Forget the faces. Forget my mother's lullaby. I will owe a favor to the

CHAPTER 6. THE BARGAIN OF THE SHED SKIN

Court."

The serpent-queen raised her head. "A favor without limit?"

"Without limit."

The queen smiled. It was the smallest possible smile, the kind that says *the book is set*. She whispered a word. The woman shed.

She slept. Dreamless. Silent. For the first time in a year, she woke without a name on her tongue.

A year passed. Then a messenger came — a child with no shadow, carrying a folded leaf.

"The Court calls," the child said. "A child has been born without a shadow. You will nurse it until the shadow returns."

The woman nursed. One year. Three. Seven. The shadow never returned. The child grew — strange, calm, watchful, always polite. Never laughed. Never cried. When the child's mother died of a fever, the child shed its own name and joined the Coil Court.

The woman was free. The favor was paid.

But she often looked at her hands in the firelight and wondered whose heartbeat she was counting. Not hers. Not the child's. Something older.

She still cannot sleep. The solitude is gone. But the faces in the shadows have returned — and now she knows their names.

The Witch's Closing

"A shedding does not erase the debt. It only changes the skin you wear. The scales remember. The shadows keep count."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Shadowless Child

A child born without a shadow — an old bargain unpaid, a debt that has grown teeth. The child is unnervingly calm. Immune to fear. Can walk thresholds that bar others — doorways without permission, wards without invitation, the edge between sleep and waking. The child may be a vessel. The child may be the debt itself.

Tags / Mechanics:

THRESHOLD [DREAD] [MARK]

- Immune to fear effects. Cannot be compelled, charmed, or intimidated by magic that targets emotion.
- Suffers -1 Position on Stealth rolls near the child. Shadows grow thin. Witnesses remember.

CHAPTER 6. THE BARGAIN OF THE SHED SKIN

- Cannot be harmed by any creature that casts a shadow. Convert all incoming Harm to Fatigue (the shadow absorbs the wound).
- Timer : *Return the Shadow* [8]. Ticks each session the child remains shadowless. When full, the original bargain finds a new debtor — possibly one of the characters.

Adventure Hook: A village is terrorized by a child who never sleeps, never blinks, and knows everyone's secrets — the ones whispered, the ones hidden, the ones not yet spoken. The child has no shadow. A Lethaiar came three years ago and claimed it as payment. Now the Lethaiar wants it back, and the child does not want to go.

Colophon

Recorded in a Coil Court antechamber, with warm milk and bitter herbs. The lamp flickered once — no draft, no dying wick. The serpent-queen did not look at me once. When I left, she whispered a single word. I will not write it here.

The Shed Skin

The dark elf peeled a flake of dead skin from her forearm and placed it in the fire.

It did not burn. It curled into the shape of a hand.

"That belonged to a liar," she said. "Now it belongs to no one."

– *Coil Court, after midnight.*

7 The Selkie's Oath

Told by

Captain Rana of the *Eel-Skiff*, a Linn woman with salt-bleached braids and a laugh like shingle in a storm. Never goes ashore without a knife. Never sleeps without the hatch cracked.

The Tale

A selkie married a fisherman. Same bargain as always: hide the skin, she stays. Lose it, she leaves.

He hid hers under the hearthstone. Ten years. Children. Mended nets. The quiet arithmetic of storms survived.

Then the youngest coughed blood into the porridge.

The nearest healer was a day's sail. The fisherman weighed the distance against the skin under the stone. His wife watched him do it.

She did not speak. She reached under the hearthstone. Pulled out the skin. Cut it into strips with his own gutting knife.

"Bandages," she said. "The child's breath is worth more than my freedom."

She wrapped the small chest. The fever broke before dawn. The skin was ruined — salt-stiff, chopped, fit only for the tide.

At first light, the fisherman touched her wrist. "Will you leave?"

She did not pull away. "I have no skin to return to."

"That is not an answer."

She turned his hand over, palm up. "I have a new oath. I choose to stay. That is heavier than any skin."

They say she grew webbing between her fingers the next winter. Her eyes turned the color of the deep — not gray, not blue, but the shifting place where light fails. The children learned to swim before they could walk.

The fisherman never asked again.

The Witch's Closing

"Oaths change. So do the skins we wear. The sea does not care which — only that you choose, and that you choose while there is still breath."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Cut Skin

A ruined selkie skin, cut into bandages, now stiff with salt and rust-colored stains. It heals any wound. It also remembers what it was.

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [CURSE] [TRANSFORM]

- Heals 1 Harm per use. The user marks 1 Fatigue after each use — not from effort, but from hearing the sea call. The call gets louder each time.
- Timer : *Sea-Change* [4]. Ticks each time the bandages are used. When full, the user gains a permanent minor mutation: webbed digits, salt-crusts skin that never dries, or eyes that reflect moonlight even indoors. No magic removes it short of a full renaming ritual at a crossroads at midnight.
- Once the timer fills, the bandages become inert. They have given everything.

Adventure Hook: A healer's bandages cure any sickness — but her patients wake dreaming of drowned cities,

of stone towers under green water, of something that breathes in the trenches. The source is a cut selkie skin, kept in a locked chest. Destroy it and lose the miracle. Keep it and learn what the sea remembers.

Colophon

Told on the deck of the *Eel-Skiff*, rain coming in from the northeast. The captain spat over the rail. "That's the truth. The rest is embroidery."

The Cloak

The Linn woman's sealskin cloak lay across her knees. She did not touch it. The story ended. The cloak had moved three inches toward the door.

– *Thing-holm, herring run.*

8 The Peddler's Swerve

Told by

Rusti the Factor, a Vilikari trader with a missing finger and a smile that never reaches her eyes. She has sold the same horse three times and still owns it. She says that is not theft. That is velocity.

The Tale

A peddler came to a border ford. The toll was high. She had no coin. She had a cart full of empty barrels — iron-hooped, tar-sealed, the kind that once held brandy from the southern islands.

"Air," she told the toll-keeper. "Fresh mountain air. The valley pays handsomely. They say the fog down there is thick enough to drown in. My customers prefer to breathe."

He laughed — a thick, wet sound. "Air? I will let you pass for a taste."

She uncorked a barrel with ceremony. Held it to his nose. Pine and snow and the particular cold that lives in high places, the kind that makes you remember a childhood you never had.

He waved her through, still laughing.

The next day, a rival told him the barrels were empty. Furious — not at the loss, at the insult — he rode after her.

She had already sold the air.

Not as air. As "breathing lessons for the rich." Copper per lungful. Copper per desperate merchant who could not afford another winter of valley lung. The barrels were full of gold now, and the air was gone.

He cornered her at the next ford. "You cheated me."

She did not flinch. "Air is free. The mountain gives it to anyone who climbs. You chose not to sell it. I did. That is not cheating. That is seeing what is in front of your face."

She paid double the original toll — from the gold — and asked, "Do you want a lesson in breathing?"

He did not answer. But the next year, he sold fog to the lowlands. Called it "cloud silk." Made a fortune.

The peddler? She kept one barrel empty. Just in case.

The Witch's Closing

"Sell the hour, not the horse. Value is not in the thing. It is in the need. And need is a thing you can put in a barrel if you name it correctly."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hollow Barrel

A barrel that appears empty but can be filled with anything people believe is inside. It works by suggestion — open it, describe the contents with enough detail, and it produces faint scent, sound, warmth, the ghost-touch of what is not there. It cannot create matter. Only perception. Only the space between what is and what is wanted.

Tags / Mechanics:

ILLUSION [TRICK] [VEIL]

- Once per scene, a character can declare that the barrel contains a plausible small object — a lock of hair, a poison, a letter, a breath of spice air. The barrel produces sensory evidence: smell, faint sound, a wisp of warmth. A Perception test at DV 3 reveals the illusion. At DV 5, the character notices that the *lack* of weight is wrong.
- Cannot create fire, light, or anything that would cause physical harm. The barrel is a liar, not a weapon.
- Used to fool guards, start rumors, create false trails, or convince a desperate person that hope is closer than it is.

- Timer : *The Barrel's Limit* [6]. Ticks each time the barrel creates an effect in a new location. When full, the barrel cracks. It can still be used, but anyone within Near range hears a faint whisper: *empty*. The jig is up.

Adventure Hook: A con artist is selling "dragon's breath" and "ghost tears" using hollow barrels. She has made enemies of three guilds and one actual ghost. Catch her — or join her. The ghost is offering better terms.

Colophon

Recorded in a Vilikari waystation, bad wine and good lies. The factor winked at me — a slow, deliberate gesture — and pointed at my notebook with the hand missing its smallest finger.

"You will sell that one day," she said.

I have not. Yet.

The Barrel

The Vilikari woman tapped a barrel. It rang hollow. "Opportunity," she said. "Every empty thing is a chance to fill it with story."

– *Waystation south of the Violet Bazaar.*

9 The Censor's Mask

Told by

Old Censor Varo, a man with one eye and a brand on his cheek — not punishment, he says, but *documentation*. He sits by the forum fountain and feeds the pigeons. Children dare each other to ask him about the mask. He always answers. That is how you know he was the worst of them.

The Tale

The Censor of Ecktoria wears a mask. Bronze, old, the eyeholes dark as a well at noon. It does not cover the face. It *replaces* it. He wears it only at the Triumph, when the city brings its petitions and its lies.

One year, a merchant offered a bribe. A bag of silver. The Censor refused. The merchant doubled it. The Censor refused again.

"Name your price," the merchant whispered.

The Censor removed the mask.

The merchant screamed. There was no face underneath. Only a hollow space, and in that hollow, a whisper: *I have seen your ledgers. Every page. Every missing grain.*

The merchant fled. The Censor put the mask back on. At the next Triumph, he wore it again.

But that night he dreamed of his own lies — the grain he had skimmed from the public store, the witness he had ignored because the bribe was smaller but sweeter. The mask had seen him too. The mask saw everyone. It simply waited.

He tried to remove it. The straps would not loosen. He cut them with a knife. The mask stayed. He heated the bronze. It cooled around his jaw. He broke a piece off with a hammer. By morning, the piece had grown back.

For a year he wore the mask. He could not eat. He could not drink. He did not starve. The mask fed on his guilt. He felt the hunger but could not die from it — suspended between confession and silence, like a fly in amber.

At the next Triumph, he walked to the forum. He knelt before the assembly. He said, "I am unworthy. I have stolen. I have lied. I have worn this mask as armor when it was meant to be a mirror. Judge me."

The mask fell off.

His face beneath was not old. It was young. His missing eye had grown back. The brand on his cheek was gone — erased, as if the skin had forgotten the iron.

He served thirty more years. The most honest Censor the city ever had. He never wore the mask again. He did

not need to. The mask had taught him where to look.

The Witch's Closing

"Judgment begins at home. The mask only shows what you already know — but will not say."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Censor's Mask

A bronze mask that shows the wearer their own hidden crimes — not visions, not revelations, just the quiet certainty of a conscience the wearer thought they had buried. It cannot be removed until the wearer confesses publicly. While worn, the wearer cannot eat or drink but does not die. Guilt is its own kind of bread.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [TRUTH] [PRESSURE]

- Wearer gains +2 dice to Insight against any deception — the mask sees through lies because it knows the shape of a lie from the inside.
- At the end of each scene where the mask is worn, the wearer must confess a secret flaw to another

person. The GM may ask: *What guilt does the mask show you right now?* If the player refuses, the timer *Confession* [4] ticks.

- When the timer fills, the wearer is compelled to make a full public confession in the next forum or marketplace they enter. The compulsion is absolute. After confession, the mask can be removed.
- A character who has worn the mask for at least a year (in-game) and then confessed gains the Condition *Unmasked*: +1 die to resist any future lie-based magic. They have seen the bottom of that well.

Adventure Hook: A city official has not eaten in three weeks. He speaks in whispers. A bronze mask has fused to his face. The party must learn what he did — and persuade him to confess before his body forgets how to want. The mask will not kill him. But it will wait.

Colophon

Forum fountain, late winter, the light thin as old milk. The old man threw a crust to a pigeon. "I was his clerk," he said. "I forged the ledgers. He wore the mask for both of us. That was the bargain." He touched his cheek — the branded side. "I got the easier half."

The Mask

The old man touched his cheek. "The brand is where the mask bit," he said. "It has no teeth. But it remembers."

– *Ecktoria, fountain of the four rivers.*

10 **The Bride of Nine Knots**

Told by

Lady Ysoria, a Vhasian widow who lives in a red tower and receives visitors only at dusk. Her left hand has six fingers. She says the extra one was a wedding gift. She did not say who gave it.

The Tale

A bride tied her dowry rope with nine knots. One for each year she waited for her betrothed while he fought wars in the southern passes. The priest said, "*Eight is custom. Nine is a door. Do not tie what you cannot untie.*"

She tied it anyway.

The morning of the wedding, her rival — who had also loved the groom, who had also waited, whose own dowry rope had only seven knots — stepped forward and cut the ninth knot with a blade of bone.

The groom forgot his vows. Not slowly. Not gently. He stood at the altar with his mouth half open, his eyes the color of a winter river, his hands empty. He did not reach for the bride. He did not speak. He simply *stopped*.

The bride did not weep. She stepped around him. She

took his hand — cold, still — and spoke for him.

“I give this ring. I take this name. I close this door. He is not here to refuse. That is not my problem. That is yours.”

She said this to the priest. The priest was afraid. He nodded. The bond held.

But the rival’s hand withered where she had cut the cord — five fingers turned to three, the skin drawn tight as dried leather, the bone showing at the knuckles. She wore a glove for the rest of her life. She never explained why.

The bride kept the severed knot in a silver locket. She wore it for fifty years. She never opened it. She never needed to.

On her deathbed, she gave the locket to her daughter.

“If you ever need to silence a liar,” she said, “cut a knot. But be sure you know whose tongue will still speak afterwards. The blade does not ask whose blood it spills.”

The daughter opened the locket. The knot was gone. Inside was a single tooth — the rival’s, yellowed, cracked.

The daughter closed the locket. She did not ask.

The Witch’s Closing

“The ninth knot is the thread that holds the story closed. Cut it, and the story unravels — but not always in the direction you expect. The blade remembers who swung it.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Severed Knot

A piece of wedding cord, kept in a locket or a box or a hollow tooth. It remembers the vow it once bound. When cut again — for it can always be cut again — it does not destroy the vow. It simply transfers the forgetting. Someone else forgets. Someone else pays.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [TRUTH] [OATH]

- As an action, cut the knot and speak the name of a vow you witnessed. The person who made that vow forgets they ever spoke it. They will not remember until someone reminds them — and the reminder is always painful.
- The cutter chooses who forgets. The cutter does not choose who pays. The GM chooses a cost: a withered hand (–1 die on physical rolls for one moon), a forgotten face (–1 die on social rolls for one moon), or a debt transferred (an enemy becomes a friend; a friend becomes a stranger).
- The knot can be cut once per season. It grows back

smaller each time. The ninth cut unravels the cutter's own name.

Adventure Hook: A noble has been forced into a marriage contract she does not want. She possesses a ninth knot — her grandmother's, passed down through three widows. Cutting the knot will make her betrothed forget his claim. But her grandmother's journal warns: "*The third cut takes a finger. The sixth takes a memory. The ninth takes everything.*" The knot has been cut six times already. The party must decide: cut again, find another way — or ask whose debt they are really paying.

Colophon

Red tower, dusk. The widow poured wine into eight cups. The ninth she emptied on the floor. "*For the ones who forgot,*" she said. "*And for the ones who will.*" The floor did not stain. The wine was older than the house.

The Knot

The Vhasian woman held up a piece of frayed rope. "This was my grandmother's," she said. "She cut it twice. Once for love. Once for hate. The rope remembers both."

– *Red tower, Vhasian border.*

II **The Bride of Nine Knots**

Told by

Lady Ysoria, a Vhasian widow who lives in a red tower and receives visitors only at dusk. Her left hand has six fingers. She says the extra one was a wedding gift. She did not say who gave it. She also did not say whether she was the bride, the rival, or the priest. Some questions are not asked in the red tower. The wine is older than the house. The silences are older than the wine.

The Tale

A bride tied her dowry rope with nine knots. One for each year she waited for her betrothed while he fought wars in the southern passes. The priest said, *“Eight is custom. Nine is a door. Do not tie what you cannot untie.”*

She tied it anyway. The ninth knot she tied with her teeth, because her hands were trembling.

The morning of the wedding, her rival — who had also loved the groom, who had also waited, whose own dowry rope had only seven knots because her family was poorer and her patience thinner — stepped forward and cut the ninth knot with a blade of bone. The blade had

been sharpened on a stone from a river that had no name. The rival had carried it in her sleeve for three years. She had not expected to use it. She had hoped not to. Hope is not a rope.

The groom forgot his vows. Not slowly. Not gently. He stood at the altar with his mouth half open, his eyes the color of a winter river, his hands empty. He did not reach for the bride. He did not speak. He simply *stopped* — like a timer whose owner has died, like a road that ends at a cliff, like a story whose last page has been torn out and burned.

The bride did not weep. Weeping would have been a kind of mercy, and she had none left. She stepped around him. She took his hand — cold, still, heavy as a bag of stones — and spoke for him.

“I give this ring. I take this name. I close this door. He is not here to refuse. That is not my problem. That is yours.”

She said this to the priest. The priest was afraid. A priest who is afraid is a priest who has seen something he cannot explain to his god. He nodded. The bond held. The god did not object. The god, perhaps, was also afraid.

But the rival’s hand withered where she had cut the cord — five fingers turned to three, the skin drawn tight as dried leather, the bone showing at the knuckles like the ribs of a wrecked ship. She wore a glove for the rest of her life. She never explained why. When children asked, she

told them she had been bitten by a horse. The children did not believe her. But they stopped asking.

The bride kept the severed knot in a silver locket. The locket had belonged to her mother, who had died in childbirth, who had never tied any knots at all. She wore it for fifty years. She never opened it. She never needed to. The knot did not rattle. It did not whisper. It simply *was* — a small weight against her chest, like a second heart that did not beat.

On her deathbed, she gave the locket to her daughter. The daughter was not the groom's child. The groom had never woken from his forgetting. He had lived another forty years, polite and vacant, a shell that ate and slept and walked to the window every morning to watch the road. He never said who he was waiting for. Perhaps he did not know.

"If you ever need to silence a liar," the bride said, "cut a knot. But be sure you know whose tongue will still speak afterwards. The blade does not ask whose blood it spills."

The daughter opened the locket. The knot was gone. Inside was a single tooth — the rival's, yellowed, cracked, with a thread of dried leather still tied around the root.

The daughter closed the locket. She did not ask. She had learned, from watching her mother, that some questions are doors. And some doors, once opened, cannot be closed again.

The Witch's Closing

“The ninth knot is the thread that holds the story closed. Cut it, and the story unravels — but not always in the direction you expect. The blade remembers who swung it. The rope remembers who tied it. The silence remembers who was supposed to speak.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Severed Knot

A piece of wedding cord, kept in a locket or a box or a hollow tooth. It remembers the vow it once bound. It does not forget. It cannot. The knot is not a thing. It is a witness. When cut again — for it can always be cut again, and again, until nothing remains — it does not destroy the vow. It simply transfers the forgetting. Someone else forgets. Someone else pays. Someone else stands at the altar with empty hands and a mouth half open, and the priest nods because he is afraid, and the god does not object.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [TRUTH] [OATH] [SILENCE]

- As an action, cut the knot and speak the name of a vow you witnessed. The person who made that vow forgets they ever spoke it. They do not forget the person. They do not forget the place. They forget only the words. The shape of the forgetting is a circle: they will walk around the memory for the rest of their lives, never crossing the threshold, never knowing why they feel cold.
- The cutter chooses who forgets. The cutter does not choose who pays. The GM chooses a cost: a withered hand (–1 die on physical rolls for one moon), a forgotten face (–1 die on social rolls for one moon), or a name traded (an enemy becomes a friend; a friend becomes a stranger; the cutter cannot remember which is which until the moon changes).
- The knot can be cut once per season. It grows back smaller each time, tighter, more reluctant. The ninth cut unravels the cutter's own name. Not slowly. Not gently. Simply — *stopped*.

Adventure Hook: A noble has been forced into a marriage contract she does not want. She possesses a ninth knot — her grandmother's, passed down through three widows, each of whom died with unopened eyes and a

smile that did not reach their throats. Cutting the knot will make her betrothed forget his claim. But her grandmother's journal warns: "*The third cut takes a finger. The sixth takes a memory. The ninth takes everything.*" The knot has been cut six times already. The thread is thin as a hair. The party must decide: cut again and accept the cost, find another way through the passes, or ask the question no one asks in the red tower: *whose debt are we really paying?*

Colophon

Red tower, dusk. The widow poured wine into eight cups. The ninth she emptied on the floor — not as a gift, not as an offering, but as a reminder. "*For the ones who forgot,*" she said. "*And for the ones who will. The floor remembers. The floor always remembers.*" The floor did not stain. The wine was older than the house, older than the bride, older than the knot. The wine had been waiting. It was still waiting.

The Gate

The Viterran man tapped the lintel with his staff. "This gate has heard a thousand lies," he said. "It opens only for the ones who admit they don't know."

– *Hedge-moot, border of Fenwood.*

12 The Stair That Was Not

Told by

Scholar Lyra, who never leaves the library and reads by candlelight. Her handwriting is too small to read without a lens. She says that is intentional. She also says the library has a ninth aisle, but no one has found it yet. She has been looking for forty years. The candles are getting shorter.

The Tale

A student climbed a stair in the Collegium of Keys. He had counted the steps: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight.

Then the ninth. There was no ninth. The stair continued anyway.

He should have stopped. Every architect in the Collegium could have told him: a stair that does not know how many steps it has is a stair that is not sure it exists. But he was young, and his thesis was due, and he had been awake for three nights. The body forgets how to be afraid when the mind is drowning.

He climbed until his legs ached. The walls changed from stone to vellum to glass — the stone of the old foun-

dations, the vellum of unbound manuscripts, the glass of a window that looks out onto a courtyard that has not existed since the fire of 1173. The steps became sentences. The banisters became arguments. The air smelled of ink and old mistakes.

At the top, a desk. No chair. No lamp. Just the desk and the dust. On it, a single page. It was his own thesis — the one he had submitted three days ago, the one he had been so proud of, the one he had shown to his advisor who had nodded and said nothing.

It was covered in corrections. Not the advisor's hand. A hand he did not recognize. The letters were small — smaller than his own, smaller than the lens could resolve. But he could read them. He could always read them. That was the worst part.

They were right. Every correction, every crossed-out line, every margin note that said *"This is where you lied to yourself"* and *"You knew this was wrong when you wrote it"* and *"Your mother's death is not an argument, it is an excuse, and you know it."*

He had been wrong. Not about the data — the data was fine. He had been wrong about the question. He had asked the wrong thing. The stair had shown him what he should have asked instead.

He wept. Not because he was sad. Because the corrections were kind. Whoever had written them had taken the

time to explain. Had drawn little diagrams in the margins. Had crossed out a paragraph and written, in letters no larger than a gnat's wing, *"Try this instead. It will hurt less when you read it in the morning."*

When he looked up, the desk was gone. The stair was gone. He was standing in the basement, holding a piece of chalk. The chalk was warm. It had been used recently.

He never told anyone what the corrections said. But his next thesis was perfect. Not clever — perfect. The examiners had no questions. The advisors had no notes. The archivists bound it in leather and placed it on the highest shelf, where the dust falls upward and the light does not reach.

He never climbed a stair without counting twice. But he also never stopped writing. Every page he wrote after that night had a small mark in the corner — a dot so tiny only he could see it. A reminder that somewhere, in a room that existed and did not exist, someone was reading. Someone was taking notes. Someone was being kind.

The Witch's Closing

"A proof that cannot be improved is already dead. A scholar who cannot be wrong is a scholar who has stopped climbing. The stair judges — but it also teaches. Accept its edits, or stay in the basement. The basement has no windows. The

basement is where old arguments go to forget themselves.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Invisible Stair

A stair that appears only to those who have made a significant intellectual error — not a small mistake, not a typo, but a wrong turn in the architecture of knowing. The kind of error that changes lives. The kind of error that, if uncorrected, will breed more errors, each one smaller and more poisonous than the last.

The stair leads to a room where the mistake is made manifest. The room is different for every climber. For some, it is a desk. For others, a mirror. For one architect in the Collegium’s records — a woman who designed a bridge that killed eleven people — the room was a narrow ledge overlooking a river she had never seen. The water was cold. The ledge was narrow. She stood there for three hours before she spoke the words that let her leave.

To leave the room, the climber must admit the error aloud. Not to anyone — the room has no witnesses except the climber and the stair. But the admission must be honest. The stair knows the difference between a confession and a performance.

Denial traps them. Not in the room — the room is

patient. It will wait. The trap is simpler: they cannot find the door. They can see it, a handspan away, but every step toward it moves them sideways. Some climbers have stayed for days. One stayed for a year. When he finally spoke the truth, he walked out and found that his wife had remarried and his children did not recognize his face. The stair did not apologize. The stair does not apologize. The stair corrects.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [DREAM] [THRESHOLD]

- **Trigger:** A character fails a Lore, Investigation, or similar knowledge-based roll by 5 or more. The failure must be significant — not a missed clue, but a genuine misunderstanding. The GM decides when the stair appears. It does not appear for every failure. Only for the ones that matter.
- **To climb:** The character must succeed on a Spirit + Lore test (DV 6). On a success, they reach the room and see their error made manifest. On a failure, they climb but cannot reach the top — the stair loops, the walls shift, and they emerge in a different part of the library (or dungeon, or forest) with no memory of what they were looking for. The stair does not forgive rushing.

- **The Correction:** After admitting the error aloud (no roll required — only honesty), the character gains +1 die to all future rolls of that skill. Not because they are smarter. Because they have seen the shape of their own wrongness. That shape is a kind of map.
- **The Cost:** The stair does not give gifts for free. The character loses something tied to the original error: a relationship that depended on their certainty, a position they held because they were “the one who knows,” or a memory of the moment they first believed the wrong thing. The GM and player choose together. The loss should sting. It should not cripple.

Adventure Hook: A scholar’s maps have been wrong for decades. She has hidden her error by avoiding the region entirely — redirecting expeditions, burning letters, silencing anyone who asked too many questions. The region is a valley in the southern passes. The people there have been waiting for help that never came. The party must find the invisible stair, climb it, correct the map — and then walk into the valley and face whatever the truth has done to the people who lived there. The scholar will not come with them. She is still in the basement. She has

been there for three years. The chalk is almost gone.

Colophon

Scriptorium of the Collegium, midnight. The scholar held up a lens. “See the margin?” she said. Her finger pointed to a blank space at the bottom of a page covered in notes. The space was not empty. There were letters there — too small to read, even with the lens. “That’s where the stair begins. It begins everywhere. You just have to look closely enough to see the step.” She blew out the candle. The room was dark. The stair was still there. It had always been there. It had been waiting for someone to stop counting and start climbing.

The Stair

The Thepyrgosi scholar pointed to a blank space on the page. "That's where the ninth step used to be," she said. "It moved."

– *Collegium of Keys, after curfew.*

13 **The Lantern That Remem- bered**

Told by

Pilot Seref, a woman with one eye and a brass hook for a hand. She captains a little cutter called the *Red Wake*. Says the sea tells her where to go. Says the sea is a poor liar but an excellent witness. When asked how she lost the eye, she taps the hook against her temple and says, "*I looked at something that did not want to be seen.*" She does not say what. The sea does not say either. The sea keeps its own accounts.

The Tale

A young pilot lit a beacon on a headland that had no name — or rather, it had too many names, and the locals could not agree which one was true. His father had lit it before him. His grandfather had built it. The stone was warm even in winter, and the wind never blew quite the same direction twice.

It was his first night alone. His father had died the week before — not at sea, but in his bed, with the taste

of salt on his lips and a question he had never asked. The young pilot did not know what the question was. He only knew that his father had stopped speaking halfway through a sentence, and the sentence had never finished.

He trimmed the lamp. He checked the mirror. He poured oil from a jug that had belonged to his great-grandmother, who had been a thief and a saint and possibly the same person. The flame burned steady. It was a small flame, no larger than a child's fist, but it threw light across the channel like a net.

At midnight, the beacon spoke.

Not in words, exactly. In a feeling — a pressure behind the eyes, a warmth at the base of the skull, a sense that something *old* was turning its attention toward him in the same way a tide turns toward a gap in the rocks.

"I have seen this coast for three hundred years," it said. "I remember every ship that broke. I remember every pilot who listened. I remember the ones who did not."

The young pilot's hands did not tremble. His father had taught him that. *"The light does not fear the dark,"* his father used to say. *"The dark is just the light's older sister. They argue. They always make up."*

"What do you want?" the pilot asked.

A pause. The flame flickered — not from wind, but from something inside the glass.

"I want someone to listen. Then I want someone to

change the light. The channel shifts. The wrecks move. I cannot move myself. I am stone. I am patient. I am also tired."

The pilot listened. He heard of wrecks he had never seen — ships that had sunk before his grandfather was born, crews that had drowned singing, a child who had floated ashore in a bread trough and grown up to be the pilot who replaced the pilot who had not listened. He heard of storms that came from nowhere and storms that came from everywhere. He heard the names of dead men spoken in a voice that was not quite a voice.

Then he climbed the tower. The ladder was cold. The rungs were worn smooth by the feet of a hundred years. He reached the lantern and turned it one degree east.

The beacon fell silent. Not an angry silence. A satisfied one. The silence of a stone that has finally settled after a long rain.

The next morning, a ship that would have wrecked passed safely. The pilot watched it from the headland, its sails white against the gray water. He did not wave. He did not cheer. He simply — *listened* — to the silence, which was not empty, which had never been empty.

He was promoted. They gave him a higher tower and a better lamp and a jug of oil that had not belonged to his great-grandmother. He never told anyone about the voice. But every time he lit a new beacon — on a new headland,

in a new channel, for a new generation of sailors who would never know his name — he spoke to it first.

"I am listening," he said. "Tell me when to move. Tell me what you remember. Tell me the names of the ones who did not listen, so I do not become one of them."

And the beacons — some of them — answered.

The Witch's Closing

"Beacons are not marks. They are arguments. A mark says, 'You are here.' An argument says, 'You should be somewhere else.' If you do not listen, the beacon will argue without you. And the sea will agree with the beacon. The sea always agrees with the oldest voice in the room."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Speaking Beacon

An old lighthouse whose flame is alive. It remembers every ship that has wrecked nearby. It can see storms days before they arrive — not because it looks, but because it *remembers* the last storm and the one before that and the one before that, and storms, like people, repeat themselves. It will share its knowledge only with those who listen — and who are willing to adjust the lantern's angle by a few

degrees, changing the safe channel. The channel is never safe for long. The sea is patient. The sea is also a liar.

Tags / Mechanics:

KNOWLEDGE [LOCATION] [TRUTH]

- A character who spends a night in the beacon and succeeds on Spirit + Lore (DV 4) gains a vision of the next storm's path — not a map, but a feeling, a pressure behind the eyes, a certainty that the wind will shift at dawn. Gain +1 die to navigation for the next leg.
- The beacon may also reveal the location of a sunken wreck (a clue, a treasure, or a body that needs to be found). The beacon does not judge the treasure. The beacon only remembers.
- If the lantern is moved without the beacon's consent — if the pilot turns the light without listening first — the beacon goes dark for a month. The pilot gains a reputation as "deaf," which is worse than being blind, because the deaf cannot hear the warnings, and the warnings are always given.
- A beacon that has been silenced for too long may begin to *forget*. A forgetting beacon is dangerous.

It may show safe water where there are rocks. It may show rocks where there is safe water. It may show nothing at all.

Adventure Hook: A coastal beacon has gone dark. Not dark like an unlit lamp — dark like a dead eye, a stopped clock, a story whose teller has walked away. Ships are wrecking on a reef that was never there before, or perhaps it was always there and the beacon had simply stopped remembering it. The party must discover why the lighthouse is silent — and whether the beacon is hiding something, grieving something, or waiting for someone. The pilot's father never finished his sentence. The party might be the ones who finish it.

Colophon

On the *Red Wake*, at anchor, with a rising tide and a sky the color of old tin. The pilot spat into the waves — not from contempt, but from custom. Her mother had spat before every voyage. Her mother's mother had spat before every birth. Spitting was a kind of prayer, she said. A prayer that did not ask for anything. A prayer that simply said, *"I am here. The water is here. That is enough."*

"She's been quiet since the war," Pilot Seref said, jerking her hook toward the darkened headland. *"I think she's*

waiting for someone. I think she's been waiting for a long time. I think she's tired of waiting."

She spat again. The tide answered. The tide always answers, even when the beacon does not.

The Beacon

The pilot pointed to a distant light. "See how it flickers?"
she said. "That's not wind. That's memory."

– *Off the Red Shoal, night.*

*CHAPTER 13. THE LANTERN THAT
REMEMBERED*

94

14 The Bell That Never Rang

Told by

Bell-warden Hollis, a gaunt man with soot under his fingernails and a cough that never quite stops. He tends the levee bells alone. When I asked why he had no assistant, he said, "The last one asked too many questions. The bell answered one of them. Neither of us liked the answer."

The Tale

A bell was cast for a tower in the Mistlands. It was large, bronze, etched with ward-runes so dense that the metal itself seemed to hold its breath. The smith who forged it lost his hearing on the day of the casting — not to the noise, but to the silence that followed. He had heard something in the cooling bronze that no living ear was meant to catch.

"Ring it once," the smith said, "and the fog retreats to the edges of the valley. Ring it twice, and the dead listen — they do not obey, but they listen, and sometimes listening is enough. Ring it thrice, and the Direwood speaks. I cannot tell you what it says. I was not brave enough to stay for the third ring."

The warden hung the bell. He polished it. He oiled

the clapper. He counted the hours without sound. The villagers grew accustomed to the silence. They forgot the bell was there. They built their lives around its promise and its refusal.

When the fog rose from the river — thick, gray, smelling of wet ash and older things — the villagers pleaded. "Ring the bell!"

He refused. "It is not time. The fog is testing us. It wants to know what we fear. If we ring too soon, it will learn."

When a child wandered into the mist — a girl of seven, chasing a fox that was not a fox — they begged at the tower door. "Ring it! The dead will help us find her."

He refused. "The dead do not help. They collect. If I ring twice, they will hear. They will come. They will find her. But they will not bring her back. They will ask what she is worth. I do not know how to answer that question."

The child was never found. The villagers never forgot. But they did not stop pleading.

When the gray wraiths came — three of them, tall as pines, silent as the bottom of a well — the villagers fled. They took their children and their livestock and what bread they could carry. They did not look back.

The warden stayed. He climbed the tower. His cough followed him up the stairs, step by step. He did not ring the bell. He stood beside it, arms spread, and said nothing.

The wraiths climbed the tower after him. They did not touch him. They circled the bell. They waited.

He waited longer.

At dawn, the wraiths withdrew. The fog lifted. The villagers returned.

They found the warden dead, his hands clasped around the clapper, his knuckles white, his mouth open in a silence that matched the bell's. He had kept it silent even as his breath left him. Even as the wraiths whispered offers. Even as the dead girl's voice called from the mist, asking him to ring it just once so she could find her way home.

He had not answered her. That was the part the villagers did not forgive.

They buried him under the tower. The bell still hangs. No one has rung it. The dead girl's voice still calls on certain nights, when the fog rises and the fox runs. She does not ask for the bell anymore. She asks for the warden.

The Witch's Closing

"Some warnings should never be spoken. The bell knows. So did he. But the girl — the girl did not know. That is the difference between the living and the dead. The dead learn too late."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Silent Bell

A bell that rings only when its guardian dies — or when someone takes their place. The note it produces is not a sound. It is a cessation of sound, a hole in the world where noise goes to die. Those who hear it do not remember the tone. They remember the silence afterward.

Tags / Mechanics:

WARD [SILENCE] [SACRIFICE] [BANISH]

- To ring the bell, a character must die while touching it. The bell tolls once — not outward, but inward — clearing all supernatural threats within a mile (fog, wraiths, hauntings, the dead girl's voice). The bell then cracks from throat to rim. It can be used only once. Afterward, the tower is silent forever.
- A character may attempt to ring it without dying by succeeding on a Body + Resolve test (DV 6). On success, they suffer 3 Harm (the bell takes what it is owed) but live, and the bell cracks but can be repaired — a task requiring a month of work and a smith who has never heard the bell's silence. On

failure, they die. The bell rings anyway. The tower is silent. There is no third option.

- The bell does not care about courage. It cares about cost. If you are not willing to pay, do not touch the clapper.

Adventure Hook: The old bell-warden lies dying in the tower. The fog is rising. The dead girl has been calling for seventy years, and the villagers have stopped hearing her — but she has not stopped calling. The warden has never told anyone the bell's secret. On his deathbed, he whispers it to the party: "Ring it and I die for nothing. Do not ring it and she calls forever. I have kept the silence for a lifetime. Now you must choose what kind of silence you will keep."

The party must decide: let the warden die in peace and become the tower's new keepers, ring the bell and lose it forever, or find a third way — perhaps into the mist, to answer the girl themselves.

Colophon

Levee tower, morning. The warden coughed into his sleeve. "No," he said, when I asked if he would ring it. "Not today. Probably not tomorrow. The bell can wait.

The bell has all the patience in the world. I do not. That is why I am still here."

He was still there when I left. I did not look back. The bell did not ring. The girl did not call. That day, the fog was thin enough to see through.

The Bell

The bell-warden pointed to a crack in the bronze. "That's where the ninth chime was," he said. "Before it learned to keep quiet."

– *Levee tower, dawn.*

15 **The Loom of Witness**

Told by

Weaver Thalia, a woman with red-stained fingers and a loom that never stops. She weaves shrouds for the guild — for the ones who die with secrets still warm in their mouths. She does not ask what the secrets are. The loom tells her anyway.

The Tale

A dyer bought a bolt of silk from a merchant who had found it in a wrecked ship, in a chest that was not locked but would not open until the fourth try. The silk was white — not the white of fresh snow, but the white of bone after the marrow has been scraped out. Heavy. Cool to the touch. The merchant said, *“This silk remembers every shame it has witnessed. It has been listening for a hundred years. Weave with care. Or do not weave at all.”*

The dyer did not believe him. He was a practical man. He believed in dye-vats, in weights and measures, in the price of madder root on the spring market. He dyed the silk crimson — three baths, twelve hours, the color of a bruise the day after the blow — and cut it into lengths for

the market.

But the silk would not leave the loom. It rewound itself at night. The threads knotted into faces — faces the dyer did not recognize at first, then faces he did. The faces whispered. They did not shout. They did not accuse. They simply *told*. Confessions the dyer had never heard, shames he had never witnessed, weights he had never placed on his own scales.

The dyer tried to burn it. He built a fire in the yard, hot enough to melt bronze. The fire turned the silk black — the black of a mouth that has been screaming for an hour and has nothing left — and the whispers became louder. Not words now. Just sound. The sound of a hundred people trying to speak at once and finding no air.

A witch came. She did not knock. The door opened for her, or perhaps it had never been closed. She touched the loom — not the silk, not the threads, but the wooden frame, worn smooth by fifty years of work.

“You did not buy the silk,” she said. “You bought the witness. It has been following you since the merchant’s stall. It will not leave until you confess.”

The dyer knelt. His knees cracked. The floor was cold. He admitted his shames — the false weights, the watered dyes, the apprentice he had blamed for his own mistake, and one more thing, smaller than the others, the thing he had almost forgotten: the cup of wine he had spilled on

a customer's gown and not paid for, forty years ago, in a town whose name he could no longer remember.

The silk loosened. Not all at once. One thread at a time, like a fist opening.

The witch cut a single thread — not from the silk, but from the air above the loom. It glowed for a moment, then dimmed.

“This is your toll,” she said. “Wear it as a bracelet. When you lie, it tightens. When you confess, it loosens. When you die, it will return to the loom. The silk is patient. The silk has time.”

The dyer wore the thread for the rest of his life. He never lied again — not because he was virtuous, but because the thread made lying uncomfortable. A small discomfort. The discomfort of a too-tight shoe, or a collar that rubs. Just enough to remind him. Just enough.

The silk was sold for a fair price — and the buyer was told its nature. The buyer was a temple. The temple hung the silk behind the altar. Confessions offered before it, the priests said, were heard more clearly. The silk listened. The silk remembered. The silk did not judge. That was the priests' job.

The Witch's Closing

“What you hide may hold you. What you confess may free you. But freedom is not the same as forgetting. The silk remembers both — the lie and the confession. It does not choose sides. It only weaves.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Witness Silk

A bolt of silk that retains memory of every wrong witnessed in its presence. It cannot be destroyed by normal fire — fire is a confessor, not a judge, and the silk has already confessed everything it knows. To unbind it, someone must confess a secret shame in front of it. The shame does not need to be large. It only needs to be true. The confession frees one yard of silk at a time. The freed silk is inert — a cloth like any other. But the yard that remains keeps listening.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [WITNESS] [BURDEN]

- A character who possesses the silk gains +1 die to Insight rolls (the silk whispers hints — not clear

answers, but textures, feelings, the shape of a lie). However, at each downtime, the GM may ask for a confession — a minor flaw, a forgotten slight, a small cruelty. If the character refuses, the silk tightens: –1 die on all social rolls until they confess. The tightening is physical. The character can feel it.

- The silk can be "paid off" by sacrificing a yard (which becomes inert cloth) in exchange for a favor from a guild or spirit. The favor is never large. The silk is not generous. But a small favor — a door left unlocked, a message delayed, a name forgotten — is sometimes enough.
- The silk has a number of yards equal to the number of confessions it has witnessed. Every new confession adds a yard. Every sacrifice removes one. The silk can never be reduced to zero. It always keeps at least one yard — the yard that witnessed its own creation, in a wrecked ship, in a chest that would not open.

Adventure Hook: A merchant's best loom is stuck — the silk will not come out. The loom has been in her family for six generations. Her grandmother wove the shrouds for the plague dead. Her great-grandfather wove the sails

for a ship that never returned. The silk knows something about each of them — something none of them confessed. The merchant is hiding a secret that could ruin her. Not a large secret. A small one. The kind that fits in a cup of wine, spilled forty years ago, in a town whose name she can no longer remember. The party must decide: extract the confession, burn the loom, or find a third way — knowing that the silk will remember whichever path they choose.

Colophon

Weaver's loft, dusk. The loom clicked — not a sound of work, but a sound of listening. Thalia touched a thread. Not the crimson silk. A different thread, gray, thin, almost invisible against her skin.

"This one is mine," she said. "I overcharged a widow. Twenty years ago. The widow is dead now. The overcharge was three coppers. The silk does not care about the amount. It only cares that I remember."

She did not cut the thread. She let it be.

The loom clicked again. Thalia did not look up.

The Thread

The weaver held up a crimson strand. "This was dyed with guilt," she said. "It never fades."

– *Silkstrand, dye ward.*

16 The Coin That Came Back

Told by

Old Salt, a Zakov pirate with a peg leg and a parrot that swears in three languages. He has been drowned twice. The sea spit him back both times, but the second time it kept his left ear. He says the ear still hears underwater. He says it hears things no living person should know. He will not say what.

The Tale

A smuggler found a coin in a dead man's eye. Not pressed into the socket—resting there, warm as a fresh egg, as if the dead man had been saving it for someone. The coin was silver, stamped with a ship that had no name, its sails furled, its masts bare. The smuggler pried it loose with two fingers. The eye did not close. The dead man did not stop looking.

He took it. A smuggler who will not take a coin from a corpse is a smuggler who has never been hungry.

That night, the coin bought him safe passage past a patrol. The watchman looked at it—just looked, just a glance—and waved him through without a word. With-

out a toll. Without a name. The watchman did not remember the encounter. Later, when asked, he said he had no memory of any ship passing that night. He said he must have been asleep. He said he never slept on watch.

The next day, the dead man's ghost sat in his cargo hold. Not floating. Not wailing. Sitting, cross-legged, on a barrel of salted herring, its hands folded in its lap, its eye sockets empty but somehow still watching.

"*You took my toll,*" the ghost said. Its voice was the sound of water finding a crack in a hull. "*Now you owe me passage.*"

The smuggler tried to sell the coin. No one would take it. Merchants looked at it and turned pale. Pawnbrokers refused to touch it. A priest of the sea-god held it in his palm, listened for a long moment, and handed it back without a word. His hand was shaking.

He tried to throw it overboard. It floated back—not drifting with the current, not washing up on the tide, but rising straight up through the water like a bubble, landing on the deck at his feet with a sound like a bell.

He tried to give it to a beggar. The beggar returned it at dawn, pale as milk, and would not say where he had found it. He only said, "*It followed me. It knows your name.*"

He sailed to a shrine of the drowned—a stone chapel built on a skerry, reachable only at low tide, its floor cov-

ered in salt and broken wishes. He placed the coin on the altar. The ghost appeared again, sitting on the altar now, its legs dangling over the edge like a child waiting for a parent.

“Not enough,” it said. “The shrine is not where I died. You must carry me to the water that took me. You must carry me to the reef. You must carry me home.”

The smuggler sailed to a reef—a place of broken ships and bleached coral, where the water was the color of bruises. He dropped the coin into the water. It did not float back. It sank, slow as a dying star, and the ghost smiled—a thin smile, a relieved smile, a smile that said *finally*—took the coin, and vanished.

The smuggler sailed home. His hold was full of fish—more than he had ever caught, more than his nets could hold, fish of species he had never seen, fish with scales the color of sunset and eyes the color of the coin. He sold them. He grew rich. He never picked up a coin from a dead man’s eye again.

But sometimes, on still nights, he hears a coin spinning on the deck of his ship. He does not look. He knows better. The dead have long memories, and the sea has a longer one, and a coin that has been returned is not a coin that has been forgotten. It is a coin that is waiting.

The Witch's Closing

“Not all treasure is worth its weight. Some coins carry a ticket. The ticket is always for a destination you would not choose. The sea does not ask whether you want to go. The sea only asks whether you are ready to pay the fare.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Ferry Coin

A silver coin taken from a corpse's eye. It cannot be spent, given away, or destroyed—not by fire, not by water, not by prayer. It follows. It waits. It knows your name. It forces the holder to carry the ghost of the dead person to the place of their death. Not the place they were buried. Not the place they were born. The place where the water took them. Once there, the coin and ghost vanish, and the holder is granted a boon of the sea: good fishing, calm waters, a safe passage, or—if the ghost is grateful—a single answer to a question about drowning.

Tags / Mechanics:

CURSE [SACRIFICE] [TRUTH]

- The holder gains +1 die on all Negotiation rolls (the coin whispers advice—the dead know things)

the living have forgotten) but suffers nightmares every night unless they are actively sailing toward the ghost's destination. The nightmares are not vague. The holder dreams the ghost's death, over and over, from the inside. Each night, the holder wakes with salt on their lips and water in their lungs.

- The ghost can be negotiated with—it might accept a substitute voyage (delivering a message, carrying an object, telling a story to a specific person) instead of a literal journey. This requires a Spirit + Lore test (DV 5). On a failure, the ghost does not refuse. It simply stares. The stare is worse than any refusal.
- The coin cannot be destroyed. It can be hidden—sealed in lead, buried in dry earth, dropped into a volcano. It will return. It always returns. The only way to be free of it is to pay the passage.

Adventure Hook: A sailor has a coin that will not let him sleep. He does not know whose ghost it is—only that the ghost is old, and patient, and has been waiting a very long time. The party must help him discover the dead person's identity and their destination before the ghost stops waiting. Because when a ghost stops waiting, it starts taking. First the sleep. Then the memories. Then the name. And then—the coin finds a new pocket.

Colophon

Zakov tavern, the *Drowned Rat*. Old Salt flipped a coin to the barkeep. “*That is a live one,*” he said. “*Keep the change. Or don’t. It won’t matter. The coin knows where you live.*” The barkeep put the coin in the till. The next morning, it was on the bar again. The barkeep has not slept since.

The Coin

The pirate held up a silver disk. "See the ship?" he said.

"No name. That's how you know it's a death charter."

– *The Drowned Rat, Zakov.*

17 **The Veil and the Cradle**

Told by

The Vizier's widow, a woman who wears a mask even inside her own home. She speaks through a silk curtain. No one has seen her face in twenty years—not her servants, not her physicians, not the priests who came to bless her late husband's tomb. The mask has seven latches. She has not opened them since the night the palace fell. She says the face beneath is not the one she was born with. She says it changed. She does not say how.

The Tale

A slave girl was bought for the magistrate's harem. She was young—too young, the other women whispered—frightened, and silent. Not the silence of patience. The silence of a throat that has forgotten how to make sound. She had been taken from a village that no longer existed, from a family whose names she had been beaten into forgetting. The magistrate's wife took pity on her. Pity in a harem is a dangerous thing. It is also the only honest thing.

"Wear a veil," the wife said. *"The magistrate will*

not see you. He sees only the silk, only the pattern, only the suggestion of a face. You may become invisible. You may become safe."

The girl wore the veil. It was pale blue, the color of a winter sky, embroidered with silver thread in patterns that shifted when she moved. She served the magistrate's table. He did not see her. She cleaned his chambers. He did not remember her. She walked the halls of the palace like a ghost—present, but never noticed, never questioned, never quite there.

For three years, she lived like this. She learned the palace's secrets: which guards slept on duty, which passages led to the garden, which courtiers were loyal and which were waiting. She could have killed the magistrate a dozen times. She did not. She was not a knife. She was a witness.

One night, the magistrate's enemy sent a knife. Not a metaphor—a blade, narrow as a finger, poisoned with something that turned the edge black. The assassin came through the window, silent as smoke, and raised the blade over the magistrate's sleeping throat.

The girl saw it. She could not call out—her voice would break the veil, and a broken veil is just a piece of cloth. She stepped between the knife and the magistrate. Not thinking. Not choosing. Simply moving, the way water moves toward a crack in a dam.

She took the blade in her chest. The veil fell. The magistrate woke to the sound of silk hitting stone.

He saw her for the first time. Her face was young—
younger than he had expected—and her eyes were the
color of the veil, winter sky, something distant and cold.

“Who are you?” he asked.

She opened her mouth. After three years of silence,
she had almost forgotten how to shape words. But she
found them.

“The one who was never there,” she said.

Then she died. The poison was fast. The magistrate
did not have time to call for a healer. He did not have time
to learn her name. He did not even have time to close her
eyes.

The magistrate had the veil woven into a shroud for
her—blue silk and silver thread, the same veil that had
hidden her, now the only thing that would touch her skin.
He kept the shroud for the rest of his life, folded in a cedar
chest beside his bed. He never opened the chest. He never
married again. He told his advisors that he had seen the
face of mercy, and mercy had not worn silk. Mercy had
worn a slave’s collar and a blade in her chest.

The assassin was never found. But the magistrate’s
enemies learned that a veil is not just a hiding place. Some-
times it is a cradle. And the ones who are invisible are the
ones who see the most clearly.

The Witch's Closing

“The veil hides. The knife reveals. The cradle holds what cannot be seen. Choose which you carry—but know that the one who carries the veil may also carry the weight of every face she has hidden from. The silence is not empty. The silence is full of names.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Silent Veil

A silk veil, pale blue with silver thread, that makes the wearer unnoticeable—not invisible, but forgettable. Guards will look past her. Servants will not remember her face. Courtiers will speak freely in her presence, not because they trust her, but because they do not see her at all. She is a gap in perception, a blind spot in the architecture of attention.

She cannot speak while wearing it, or the effect breaks. Not gradually. Not with a warning. The moment her voice leaves her throat, every eye in the room will turn to her. Every guard will remember the face they did not see. Every door will close.

Tags / Mechanics:

STEALTH [CURSE] [SILENCE]

- While wearing the veil, the character gains +2 dice to Stealth and Deception to avoid notice. She may walk through crowds, past guards, across courtyards, as long as she does nothing to draw attention. She may open doors, pick locks, take objects—as long as she is quick and quiet. But the moment she speaks, the veil becomes just a piece of cloth.
- The veil does not hide sound. Footsteps, breathing, the rustle of fabric—these can still be heard. A guard listening at a door will know someone is there. He just will not remember who.
- Each scene, the GM may ask the character to test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4). On failure, the character feels compelled to speak—a gasp, a cough, a whispered prayer. The compulsion is not magical. It is the weight of three years of silence pressing against the inside of her ribs. On failure, the veil's effect ends for the scene, and nearby creatures are alerted.
- Removing the veil is an action. Replacing it is also an action. The veil does not forgive interruption. Once broken, it takes a full day of wearing it in silence for the effect to return.

Adventure Hook: A noble's daughter has been sold into a hostile court—a marriage she did not choose, to a man she has never met, in a city where she has no allies. She possesses a veil that makes her unnoticeable, but she cannot speak while wearing it. The party must smuggle her out of the court without being seen, without raising the alarm, and without her breaking the silence. But the veil has a cost: every hour she wears it, she forgets another face. First her mother's. Then her father's. Then her own. By the time she reaches the gate, she may not remember why she wanted to leave.

Colophon

A room behind a curtain. No window. No second door. The widow poured tea into a cup she could not see—her hands knew where the cup was, had known for twenty years. The cup rattled against the saucer. *"I wore it for twenty years,"* she said. *"Now I do not need it. The silence is inside me. It has always been inside me. The veil was just a way of keeping it company."* She did not drink the tea. The tea grew cold. The curtain did not move.

The Veil

The widow touched the silk. "I could tell you my name," she said. "But then you would have to forget it." She did not tell me.

– Ashaan, garden of the black fountain.

18 The Ford That Moved

Told by

Ferryman Dav, a Dhaharan with a turban and a voice like gravel rolled downhill. He poled his boat across the same ford for fifty years. He says the river changed course three times in his lifetime—once after a flood, once after a famine, and once after a wedding where the groom forgot the bride’s name halfway through the vows. He does not know which change was which. He only knows the river has moods, and the moods have teeth.

The Tale

A caravan master needed to cross a ford. The river was high, the stones slick as oil, the current muttering to itself in a language that sounded like breaking glass. He had crossed this ford a hundred times. This time, it felt different. This time, the water was watching.

He knelt and prayed to the ford—not to the river, not to the god of rivers, but to the ford itself, the place where water met stone and stone let travelers pass. He offered a single grain of wheat, held between thumb and forefinger, small as a promise.

"I will stay still for one crossing," the ford whispered. The voice came from nowhere and everywhere—from the water, from the stones, from the air just above the surface. *"Then you will owe me a name."*

The caravan master crossed. The ford held. The water did not rise. The stones did not shift. He reached the far shore with dry boots and a wet back—his own sweat, not the river's.

The next night, he returned. The river was different—deeper, swifter, darker. The ford had moved. The crossing was a hundred paces downstream, and the old path was now a whirlpool the size a horse could drown in.

"Name a price," the merchant said.

"You have already named it," the ford replied. Its voice was softer now, almost kind. Almost. *"The name of your firstborn child. The name you whisper when you think no one is listening. The name you have kept folded in your chest like a letter you are afraid to send."*

The merchant had no child. He was childless. His wife had died in the winter. He had buried her with his own hands, and he had not wept then, but he wept now—great heaving sobs that echoed off the water and came back to him twisted, mocking.

The ford softened. The current slowed. The stones rose just enough to offer a path.

"Then give me the name you would have given them."

The name that died in your throat when your wife died. The name that has no grave, no marker, no witness. Give me that name. And every year, on this night, return and speak it again. That is the toll. That is always the toll."

The merchant knelt. He pressed his forehead to the wet stones. He whispered a name—a name no one had ever heard, a name he had never spoken aloud, a name that existed only in the space between his heartbeat and his breath.

The ford calmed. The water stilled. He crossed safely, and the far shore rose to meet him like an old friend.

He returned every year. He spoke the name. The ford accepted it, drank it, swallowed it whole. His wife did not come back. The child did not appear. But the name—the name stayed alive, spoken once a year into the water, and the water carried it somewhere the merchant could not follow.

His wife gave birth to a daughter. He named her the same name. The ford never troubled him again. But the daughter—the daughter sometimes woke from dreams she could not remember, with salt on her lips and the sound of water in her ears. She never learned to swim. She never wanted to.

The Witch's Closing

"A road is a covenant. A ford is a witness. The river remembers every name it has been given. It does not forget. It does not forgive. It only waits for the next traveler who thinks a grain of wheat is enough."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Naming Ford

A river crossing that asks for a name as toll. Not a coin. Not a prayer. A name. It will accept a false name once—once, and only once, and only if the false name is beautiful enough to make the water laugh. The next crossing demands the true name of the traveler. Not the name on their papers. Not the name their mother gave them. The name they whisper to themselves in the dark, when they are afraid, when they are alone, when they are not sure they deserve to exist.

If the traveler refuses, the ford shifts its course—sometimes by a few paces, sometimes by a mile, sometimes by a generation. It becomes impassable for a year and a day. By then, the traveler is usually dead, or lost, or someone else entirely.

Tags / Mechanics:**THRESHOLD [TRUTH] [SACRIFICE]**

- To cross, a character must succeed on a Spirit + Lore test (DV 3) to recall a name that has meaning—not necessarily their own, but a name that cost them something to learn. On failure, the ford demands a true name from one of the party. That character gains a String on themselves (the ford knows their name, and the river remembers). Water magic targeting that character gains +1 die for the next moon. The ford does not explain this. The ford does not need to.
- If the party tries to cross without paying, the ford becomes a hazard: Athletics DV 5 to navigate the shifting stones and sudden currents. On failure, the character is swept downstream, loses 1 Supply, and arrives at the far shore with wet boots and a new understanding: the ford was being polite before. It has stopped being polite.
- A character who pays the ford with a true name may, once per session, ask the GM: “*What does the river know that I do not?*” The GM answers with a single fact about the nearest body of water—a hidden current, a drowned body, a secret the water

has kept. The answer is always true. The answer is never comforting.

Adventure Hook: A ford has closed to all trade. The local lord sent a surveyor; the surveyor returned, but he cannot remember his own name. He knows his face. He knows his horse. He knows the way home. But when someone asks “*who are you?*” he opens his mouth and nothing comes out—only the sound of water, distant and cold. The party must learn what the ford took—and whether a name, once given, can ever be returned. The river says no. The river has been wrong before. Not often. But once is enough.

Colophon

Ferryman’s hut, near the saffron fields. Dav spat into the water. The water spat back. “*She is quiet tonight,*” he said, wiping his cheek. “*Must have taken a good one. A ripe one. A name with weight.*” He poled his boat into the current. The river did not move. It was waiting. It is always waiting.

The Ford

The ferryman pointed at a ripple. "That's where the name lives," he said. "It's been there thirty years. It never ages."

– *Dhahara, upper ford.*

19 The Fog Road

Told by

Mist-walker Kell, an old Ubral woman who lives in a cairn and never lights a fire. She says the fog is not a thing. It is a question. She says fire makes the question impatient. The patient question is the one you can answer. The impatient question eats.

The Tale

A child got lost on the moor. The fog came down thick and gray—not rolling, not drifting, but lowering like a lid. She could not see her feet. She could not see her hands when she raised them to her face. She walked for hours, but always returned to the same stone. The stone was flat and warm, though there was no sun. She sat on it. She waited.

A voice spoke from the mist. Not loud. Not close. It came from everywhere at once, like the sound of a bell that had been struck a long time ago and was still ringing.

"Who walks on my road?"

"I do," said the child. Her voice was small. The fog did not swallow it. The fog carried it, further than she

expected, as if the moor were listening.

"Are you lost?"

"I am lost," she said.

"Are you?" said the voice. *"You are walking exactly where I need you. You have not missed any turns. You have not taken any wrong roads. You have simply not arrived yet. That is not the same as being lost. That is called traveling. But you still have not answered my first question. Who walks?"*

The child thought. She could not give her name—names are for daytime, for hearths, for people who know where they belong. She could not say her clan—clans are for fires, and there were no fires here. She could not say where she was from, because the fog had erased the direction.

She thought of what her grandmother had told her, once, when the fog came down around their wagon: *"The moor does not take those who belong to it. It only takes those who argue."*

"Someone who belongs to the fog," she said.

The voice laughed. Not a cruel laugh. A surprised laugh. A laugh that said *you are the first person to say that in a hundred years.*

"Then you may stay. Not forever. Just until you find the stones."

The fog parted. Not all at once—slowly, like a curtain

drawn by a patient hand. The child saw a path of white stones, each one placed just far enough from the next that she had to stretch. She followed it home.

At the edge of the moor, she looked back. The fog was gone. The moor was ordinary grass and heather. She did not tell anyone what she had seen. She did not need to. Her grandmother knew.

"You walked with the Urisk," her grandmother said. "It asks every traveler the same question. Most answer with their names. Then it keeps them. It does not take their lives. It takes their *arrival*. They walk and walk and never reach the edge. They are still walking. They have been walking for centuries. They are not unhappy. They are just... not home."

The child touched the stone in her pocket. She did not remember picking it up. It was warm. It was flat. It was the same stone.

She kept it for seventy years. When she died, her daughter placed it back on the moor. The fog came down that night. It has not lifted since.

The Witch's Closing

"The fog does not hide. It asks. It asks if you belong. If you do, it will guide you. If you do not, it will keep you—horribly, not kindly, just... permanently. The moor has a

long memory. It remembers every answer it has ever heard. It is still waiting for the right one.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Urisk of the Moor

A spirit of the fog. It appears to lost travelers and asks, “*Who walks on my road?*” It does not repeat the question. It does not clarify. It asks once, and the answer decides everything. If the traveler gives a name—any name, true or false—the Urisk learns it and may use it to compel the traveler to stay. Not to hurt them. To *keep* them. The moor is lonely. The Urisk is old. Loneliness is not malice, but it is not kindness either.

If the traveler claims belonging to the fog—not ownership, not mastery, but belonging, the way a stone belongs to the hill, the way rain belongs to the sky—the Urisk guides them safely and may become an ally. It will not appear when called. It will not answer questions. But the fog will never hide the path from that traveler again.

Tags / Mechanics:

SPIRIT [THRESHOLD] [TRUTH]

- To negotiate with the Urisk, a character must suc-

ceed on a Spirit + Lore test (DV 4) while offering a truth about themselves that is not their name. A memory. A regret. A hope. Something the fog can hold. On success, the Urisk parts the fog, and the character may re-roll any failed navigation check on the moor for the rest of the journey. On failure, the Urisk does not harm them. It simply says, “*Not yet. Walk further.*” And the fog does not lift.

- If the character gives their name—even in panic, even accidentally—the Urisk can later appear at a dramatic moment, offering a choice: a path that seems easy but leads to danger, a shortcut that costs more than it saves, a door that opens onto a room the character has already left. The GM gains 3 SB to spend on complications related to *getting lost*. The character does not need to accept the Urisk’s offered path. But they will see it. They will always see it.
- A character who successfully claims belonging to the fog gains the following: once per session, when they are lost (geographically, morally, or narratively), they may ask the GM, “*Which way feels like home?*” The GM answers honestly, though not always clearly. The fog remembers its own.

Adventure Hook: A shepherd's child has vanished into the fog. The villagers are afraid to search—not because they are cowards, but because three other children vanished in the same fog twenty years ago, and none of them came back. The party must find the Urisk and answer its question. But the fog is thick, and the moor is wide, and the Urisk has heard a great many names. It is still waiting for the right one. It is not impatient. It has never been impatient. That is what makes it dangerous.

Colophon

Cairn on the high moor. The old woman did not light a candle. She did not need one. The fog was bright enough.

“Light attracts the wrong things,” she said. “The dark is easier to negotiate with. In the dark, you can hear the questions before you see the teeth. In the light, the teeth are all you see.”

She poured a cup of water onto the stone floor. The water did not pool. It vanished.

“The moor is thirsty,” she said. “It has been thirsty for a long time. The fog is just its breath. Do not hold your breath back. The moor does not like to wait.”

The Fog

The Ubral woman pointed to a blank space in the air.
"There," she said. "Do you see it? That's where the Urisk
was standing. It just left."

– *High moor, twilight.*

20 **The Counting of the Fifth Breath**

Told by

Sergeant Relled, a Black Banner mercenary with a missing ear and a habit of counting his steps. He has survived seven campaigns. He does not know why. He has stopped asking. The asking, he says, is what gets you killed. The counting keeps you alive.

The Tale

A young captain lost his nerve in a skirmish in the Singing Wastes. Not his sword arm. Not his voice. His nerve. The kind that sits behind the ribs and tells the hands what to do when the mind has frozen. The enemy had five breaths to plant a banner on the ridge. Five heartbeats. Five chances. Five ways to lose everything.

The captain panicked. Not the dramatic panic of a screaming recruit. The quiet panic. The one where the eyes go wide and the mouth opens and nothing comes out.

"I have four breaths left," he told his sergeant. His

voice was the sound of a blade scraping a stone. *"What do I do?"*

The sergeant did not panic. The sergeant had survived seven campaigns by not panicking. He looked at the ridge. He counted. Not the breaths. The exits.

"How many ways up?"

"Two."

The sergeant nodded. *"Then they are already dead. They just do not know it yet. Weld one path. Block the other. Use the first breath to drink water. Your mouth is dry. Dry mouths make bad decisions."*

The captain drank. His hand stopped shaking.

The sergeant welded the path with a line of reds—not a wall, not a barricade, just a suggestion of fire, a promise of pain. The enemy runner hesitated. Hesitation is a kind of death. It is not quick. It is not clean. But it is final.

The captain's second breath, he moved an orange to fork the ridge. Not to attack. To divide. An enemy that must choose is an enemy that has already lost the advantage of speed.

Third breath, he planted a green on the low path. Not a soldier. A flag. A suggestion that someone was already there. The enemy runner stopped. He looked at the flag. He looked at the ridge. He looked at the burning path.

Fourth breath, the captain waited.

Waiting is the hardest breath. The lungs want to

empty. The hands want to move. The heart wants to do *something*—anything—even the wrong thing. The captain waited.

The enemy runner never reached the ridge. The fifth breath expired. The banner stayed in its scabbard. The captain won.

Later, the sergeant sat with him by the fire. The captain's hands were still shaking, but his voice was steady.

"How did you know?"

"I did not know," the sergeant said. "I counted. Counting is not knowing. Counting is buying time to think. Panic is a thief. It steals the breaths you cannot afford to lose. Do not let it. Count the breaths. Then count your exits. Then count your water. Then move. In that order. Never skip the water. Dry mouths make bad decisions."

The Witch's Closing

"Calm is not a gift. It is a habit. Spend your first breath on it. The rest will follow—or they will not. But at least you will have spent the first breath well."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Five-Breath Timer

A timer that appears when a character is in a desperate race—a siege, a chase, a ritual, a collapsing ceiling, a burning ship. Not a magical construct. Not a curse. Simply the shape of pressure made visible: five breaths, counting down. The character can see the count—not as numbers, but as a sensation behind the eyes, a tightness in the chest, a voice that whispers *five, four, three* with every heartbeat.

The timer is not an enemy. The timer is a mirror. It shows what you are made of.

Tags / Mechanics:

PRESSURE [DREAD] [TRUTH]

- When the timer appears, the character gains +1 die to all actions directly related to the objective—panic focus, the body’s cruel gift of narrow attention. But they suffer –1 die to all other actions. Tunnel vision. The enemy in the corner of the eye. The step they did not see.
- If the timer reaches zero, the objective fails—but failure is not the end. Failure is a door. The GM may offer a Devil’s Bargain: succeed anyway, but

lose something else. A memory. A name. A breath you will never get back.

- The character can reset the timer by finding a new approach—a side path, a different tactic, a sacrifice the enemy did not expect. This requires a Wits + Tactics test (DV 4). On a failure, the timer does not reset. It simply... watches. Waiting is the hardest breath.

Adventure Hook: A mercenary company is trapped in a collapsing fortress. They have five minutes before the enemy breaches the inner gate. The captain carries a magical hourglass—not one that measures time, but one that *remembers* it. The hourglass ticks audibly, and with each tick, a grain of sand falls not into the bottom chamber, but into a third chamber no one has ever seen. The captain does not know what happens when that chamber fills. Neither does the sergeant. Neither does the enemy. The party must complete their escape—or find a way to break the hourglass before everyone discovers the answer together.

Colophon

Campfire near the Singing Wastes. The wind carried voices from the dunes—old voices, hungry voices, voices that had been counting for centuries. The sergeant ignored them. He counted his fingers instead. *“Five,”* he said. *“Always check after a fight. You never know when one went missing. Fingers, ears, breaths. Check them all. Then drink water. Dry mouths make bad decisions.”* He drank. The wind stopped. The voices went elsewhere, looking for someone who would listen.

The Count

The mercenary held up five fingers. "This is what a battle is," he said. "Five breaths. Use them well."

– *Black Banner camp, dawn.*

21 The Saffron Gate

Told by

Merchant Zara, a Fhara woman who wears bells on her ankles and never haggles at the first offer. She says patience is a type of geometry, and silence is a type of currency, and the best bargains are the ones where both parties walk away feeling slightly robbed. She has never lost a negotiation. She has also never won one. She says that is the same thing.

The Tale

A merchant came to the Saffron Gate. It was high as three men, carved with lions whose eyes followed the traveler, and guarded by two men who did not blink. Not once. Not even when dust blew into their faces. Not even when the merchant waved his hand in front of their eyes. They were not breathing. The merchant chose not to notice this.

"Toll is one truth," said the gate. The voice came from the lions, or from the guards, or from the stone itself. The merchant could not tell. He decided it did not matter.

He offered, *"I am honest."*

The gate did not open. The lions blinked. The mer-

chant felt something behind his ribs shift—a small weight, like a coin sliding off a ledge.

He offered, *“My goods are pure.”*

The gate did not open. The guards breathed in, once, together, like a bellows drawing air. The merchant felt another weight shift.

He offered, *“I have never cheated a customer.”*

The gate swung open. Not slowly, not ceremoniously. Quickly, the way a door opens when someone on the other side has been holding the handle, waiting. The merchant stepped through. His legs were unsteady. His mouth was dry.

Inside, a woman sat on a stool. She had no bells on her ankles. She had no goods to sell. She had only her hands, folded in her lap, and her eyes, which were the same color as the gate’s stone.

“You have just told three truths,” she said. *“The first was a boast. The second was a claim. The third was a lie. The gate only opens for lies. Did you not read the inscription?”*

The merchant looked back at the gate. There was an inscription. He had not read it. He had been too busy thinking about profit margins.

“Then what is the toll?”

“The knowledge that you are a liar,” said the woman. *“Not the knowledge that you have lied. You knew that. The knowledge that you are a liar—that lying is not something*

you do, but something you are. That is the toll. That is the only toll the gate accepts.”

She stood. She walked past him, through the gate, and vanished. The gate did not close. The merchant stood in the threshold for a long time, his goods on his back, his ledger in his pocket, his three truths still hanging in the air behind him.

He walked through. He did his business. He returned home. He never told anyone what he had learned. But he stopped believing his own stories. Not all of them. Just the ones where he was the hero.

The gate, they say, is still open. It is waiting for the next traveler who believes their own lies. The lions are still watching. The guards are still not breathing.

The Witch’s Closing

“A lie that you believe is not a lie. It is a cage. The gate opens from the inside, but only when you stop pretending you have the key. The key was never yours. The key was the door.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Truth Gate

A magical gate, carved into a mountain pass or standing alone in a desert, that opens only when a character speaks a falsehood they genuinely believe—not a deliberate lie, not a tactical misdirection, but a self-deception so deep that the character has mistaken it for the shape of their own face. The gate does not judge. The gate does not punish. The gate simply opens, and on the other side is a small, quiet room where a woman sits on a stool, waiting to tell you what you already know but have not yet said aloud.

Tags / Mechanics:

TRUTH [THRESHOLD] [REVELATION]

- A character must declare a truth about themselves that is actually false. The GM may ask the player to describe the belief—not its origins, not its justifications, just the belief itself, stripped clean. If the GM judges that the character genuinely believes it (not knows it to be false, not suspects it might be shaky, but *believes*), the gate opens.

- Once opened, the character gains +1 die to all Insight rolls regarding that specific subject for the remainder of the campaign. They have seen their own blind spot. They cannot un-see it. The blind spot does not close; it simply becomes visible, like a crack in a wall that has always been there, waiting to be noticed.
- The gate will not open for obvious lies, boasts, or rhetorical flourishes. It will not open for lies the character knows are lies. It will open only for the lies the character has mistaken for oxygen.
- A character may attempt to open the gate more than once, but the toll increases. The second truth costs a memory. The third costs a name. The fourth—there is no recorded fourth. The woman on the stool does not speak of it.

Adventure Hook: A diplomat has been sent to open a sealed mountain pass—the only route through before winter closes the high roads. The pass is barred by a Saffron Gate. The gate requires a self-deception. The diplomat believes she is the best negotiator in the land, beloved by all, incapable of failure. She is none of these things. She has never been any of these things. The party must find a way to help her see the truth before the snow falls—or find

someone else who can lie to themselves more convincingly. But the gate knows. The gate always knows.

Colophon

Saffron bazaar, afternoon. The sun was the color of the gate's stone. Zara counted coins into eight piles. The ninth she left empty. Not as a toll. Not as an offering. As a reminder.

"For the lie I believe," she said. *"And for the one I have not yet told."* The empty pile did not move. The coins did not shift. But for a moment—just a moment—the ninth pile seemed deeper than the others. As if something had been placed there. As if something had always been there, waiting to be noticed.

The Gate

The Fhara woman touched the padlock on her chest. "This is the gate I carry," she said. "It only opens when I admit I am wrong."

– *Saffron bazaar, after trading.*

22 The Grain That Spoke

Told by

Granary-keeper Oris, a heavy man with a gentle voice and a ledger that never balances. He says the silo talks to him when the wheat is low. He says it does not whisper—it *instructs*. He does not know the difference anymore. He is not sure there is one.

The Tale

A clerk was tallying grain in the silo. The hour was late. The lamp was dying. His fingers were black with dust. He counted aloud, because counting aloud was the only way to stay awake: one sack, two sacks, three, four, five, six, seven, eight.

“*Ninth*,” whispered the grain.

Not a voice, exactly. A rustle. A shift. The sound of one kernel settling against another in a way that formed a word. He had been taught: never count the ninth. The ninth is not grain. The ninth is a door. The ninth has teeth.

He stopped. He looked. The grain had shifted—not much, just a finger’s width, just enough to leave a small

hollow in the pile. In the hollow, a single kernel lay on the floor, separate from the rest, warm as breath.

He picked it up. It sat in his palm like a living thing. He put it in his pocket. He did not know why. He had not decided to. His hand moved, and the kernel was gone, and the silo was dark, and he was afraid.

That night, he dreamed of debtors. Not strangers—people he knew. Farmers who had borrowed seed and not repaid. Widows who owed for flour. A fisherman who had taken grain against a catch that never came. Their names were scratched into his ledger, each one a small wound in the page. In the dream, the names glowed. The grain whispered each one, slow as a tide: *“You could. You should. You will not.”*

He woke. He walked to the ledger. He forgave three names—drew a line through them, wrote *“paid”* in a hand that was not quite his own. The ink was warm. The page did not stain.

The next day, the grain was heavier. He could feel it when he climbed the silo steps—a weight that pushed back against his feet, a fullness that hummed. He counted again. Eight sacks. The ninth was full of light—not sunlight, not lamplight, but a pale, grain-colored glow that came from inside the pile, from somewhere deep, from somewhere that had not seen the sky in years.

He forgave another debtor. The grain remained full.

He forgave another. The grain rose higher in the bins.

For a year, he forgave one debtor each night. Not the ones who owed the most—those he left for the morning, when the grain was quiet. He forgave the ones the grain named. The ones it whispered for. The ones it seemed to love.

The granary never emptied. The villagers called it a miracle. The priest called it suspicious. The clerk said nothing. What could he say? *“The grain speaks to me. It tells me who to spare. I listen because I am afraid of what would happen if I did not.”*

When he died—in the silo, at midnight, with a kernel in his hand—they found the grain had gone still. Not empty. Still. As if it had been holding its breath for a year, waiting for him to stop, waiting for the next clerk to arrive. The kernel in his hand had grown into a small, green shoot, pale as bone, fragile as a promise. They planted it by the silo. It did not take root. It withered by morning.

The grain never spoke again. Or perhaps it did, and the next clerk was simply not listening. The villagers could not tell. The grain was heavy. The grain was quiet. The grain was just grain.

The Witch's Closing

“Mercy enriches the giver—but only the mercy that costs something. The grain knows. It counts only the eighth name, the one you chose to spare when the ledger told you to collect. The ninth name belongs to the silo. The silo never forgives.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Speaking Grain

A silo of grain that whispers the names of those who are in debt—not the debts of coin, but the older debts: the borrowed time, the unreturned kindness, the favor asked and never acknowledged. The grain can be used to “pay” a debt. Not with silver. With mercy. Forgive the debtor, and the grain replenishes itself. Use the grain for profit instead, and the silo empties—not suddenly, but slowly, kernel by kernel, until nothing remains but dust and the memory of a whisper.

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [TRUTH] [SILENCE]

- Once per week, the grain reveals one name—someone who owes a debt (material, emotional, or magical)

to the person who holds the silo's key. The GM chooses the name. The debt must be real, and it must be unpaid. The grain does not lie.

- The holder may choose to forgive that debt. If they do—publicly, irrevocably, without expectation of return—the grain produces 1 Supply (as if a new shipment had arrived from nowhere). The Supply is real. It can be sold, eaten, or planted. It leaves no trace.
- If the holder chooses to collect the debt instead, or simply ignores the whisper, the grain becomes stale. It provides no benefit for one month. The silence is the punishment. The holder dreams of empty bins.
- The grain does not speak to everyone. It chooses. It is not known why.

Adventure Hook: A village granary is overflowing despite a drought that has lasted two seasons. The keeper has grown rich—he sells the grain at triple price, and the hungry pay because they have no choice. But he has stopped forgiving debts. The grain still speaks his name every night. He does not listen. The party must learn the secret of the silo and decide: break the cycle, silence the grain, or be-

come the next keeper. The grain is patient. The grain is always patient.

Colophon

Granary, evening. Oris held up a single kernel between his thumb and forefinger. The light passed through it—not brown, not gold, but something else, something that had no name in any language he knew. *“This is the first one,”* he said. *“It still speaks. But I do not listen anymore. Listening changed the grain. Not listening changes me. I do not know which change is worse.”* He put the kernel back in his pocket. The pocket was empty. The kernel was not there. He did not check. He did not need to. The kernel was always there, waiting, warm as breath, patient as stone.

The Grain

The granary-keeper poured a handful of wheat into my palm. "Count it," he said.

I counted eight.

"Good," he said. "There is no ninth. That is the mercy."

– *Osbeera, river silo.*

23 The Bargain of the Unlit Lamp

Told by

A Trow who gave no name. It sat in the corner of the tavern, smoking a pipe that had no ember and no stem—just a bowl, cradled in gray fingers, empty but somehow still drawing. Its voice was dry leaves skittering across stone. Its hat drank the starlight. I wrote what I heard. When I checked my notes the next morning, the ink had faded. I rewrote from memory. The memory was not mine. I do not know whose it was.

The Tale

A traveler came to a crossroads at midnight. Not the kind of crossroads where two roads meet—the older kind, where the path between the living and the hollow crosses itself, where the shadows lean the wrong way, where the wind smells of extinguished hearths. A figure waited there. It wore a gray robe and a hat that drank the starlight. Its face, if it had one, was hidden. Its hands, if it had them, were folded.

“I am a Trow,” it said. “We trade in absence. We deal in the spaces where things used to be. What do you lack?”

The traveler lacked nothing. He was wealthy, healthy, happy, loved. He had a wife who smiled when he entered a room. He had children who ran to meet him at the gate. He had a dog that slept on his feet. He had a house with a door that swung true and a roof that did not leak.

"Then sell me something you do not need," said the Trow. "A memory you have not used in years. A breath you were going to waste. A name you have never spoken aloud. A glove that has a match. A single heartbeat from the pile of thousands."

The traveler laughed. The laugh was small and thin. The crossroads did not echo. Nothing echoes at a Trow's crossroads. He pulled off his left-handed glove—a good glove, leather, warm, but he had another just like it—and held it out.

The Trow took the glove. It did not put it on. It folded it once, twice, three times, until the glove was the size of a coin, and then it tucked the folded glove into its sleeve. The sleeve did not bulge. The sleeve had been waiting.

The Trow gave him a lamp—a small thing, brass, unlit, with a wick that looked like it had never seen flame. *"The light will not fade,"* it said. *"It will burn forever. It will never need oil. But you will forget why you needed it. You will forget what you wanted to see. The light remembers. You will not."*

The traveler took the lamp. He walked home. The

light guided him—a steady, warm glow that showed every root, every stone, every shadow that might hide a hole. But when he arrived at his gate, he paused. The gate looked wrong. The paint was the right color, but the shape was unfamiliar. He opened it. The path to the door was the same length, but the door itself—the door was not his door.

He opened it anyway. Inside, a woman looked up from the hearth. Her face was kind. Her hair was gray. He did not know her.

“Who are you?” he asked.

She stared. *“I am your wife.”*

“I do not have a wife,” he said. He meant it. He could not remember ever having a wife. He could not remember ever being loved. The lamp burned steadily in his hand, warm as a heartbeat, patient as stone.

He turned and walked back to the crossroads. The Trow was gone. The only thing on the ground was his glove—unfolded, full-sized, lying in the dust as if it had been dropped by someone in a hurry. He put it on. The lamp went out. The darkness was absolute. He sat in it for a long time, remembering.

He remembered his wife’s face. He remembered her name. He remembered the way she laughed when he tripped over the dog. He remembered the dog. He remembered everything the lamp had taken, and he remembered

that he had given it willingly, and he remembered that he had laughed.

He left the lamp at the crossroads. He walked home in the dark. He did not look back. The lamp was still there the next morning, and the next, and the next. No one took it. The Trow did not return.

He never bought from a Trow again. But sometimes, on winter nights, when the wind was right, he would stand at his gate and look toward the crossroads. He could not see the lamp. It was too far. But he could feel it—waiting, burning, remembering everything he had been willing to forget.

The Witch's Closing

“Trow trade in gaps. The gap that light fills is the gap where memory used to be. Do not buy a lamp from a creature that wears a hat made of starlight. The hat is not the problem. The hat is just a hat. The problem is the seller. The seller does not need your glove. The seller needs your forgetting.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Trow Lamp

A lantern that never needs oil and never goes out—not for lack of fuel, not for lack of air, not for lack of time. It burns on absence. It feeds on what you no longer remember. Each hour it burns, the user loses a random memory—a face, a word, a route, a name, a scar, a song, the smell of rain on dry ground, the sound of a specific voice laughing. The light is perfect. The cost is everything. Once lit, the lamp cannot be extinguished except by returning the price paid—and the Trow will accept that return only once, only at the same crossroads, only at midnight. The Trow is patient. The Trow is always there.

Tags / Mechanics:

LIGHT [CURSE] [SILENCE] [SECRET]

- The lamp provides perfect illumination in a 30-foot radius. No shadows. No blind spots. No hiding. The light does not flicker. The light does not judge. The light simply *shows*.
- Every hour of continuous use, the GM erases one minor fact from the character's background—the name of a childhood friend, the layout of a familiar

city, the face of a parent, the way home. The character may still know the fact exists. They cannot recall it under pressure. They cannot find it when they need it. It is a hole in their head, warm and smooth and empty.

- After 8 hours of cumulative use, the character cannot remember their own name. After 16 hours, they cannot remember why they are holding a lamp. After 24 hours, they cannot remember how to speak. The lamp burns on. The light is still perfect.
- To extinguish the lamp, the character must give up something of equal value to what they originally paid—not a glove, this time, but something that costs. A cherished possession that cannot be replaced. A close relationship, burned and broken. A skill point, lost as if it had never been learned. A memory they were trying to keep. The Trow will know if the payment is false. The Trow always knows.

Adventure Hook: A lighthouse keeper has used a Trow lamp for thirty years. The light has never failed. Ships have never wrecked on his shore. But the keeper has forgotten his own daughter's name—and her face, and the way to the village, and the reason he ever wanted a lamp

in the first place. He sits in the tower, staring at the flame, while the sea rises and the rocks grow sharper. The party must convince him to extinguish the light before the next storm—or find a way to pay the Trow's price themselves. The lamp is patient. The lamp is always patient. The storm is not.

Colophon

Tavern corner, after midnight. The Trow smiled. Its teeth were gray as sea-worn stone, set in gums the color of old parchment. *"I will take that question,"* it said. *"You have already forgotten you asked it. The forgetting is the payment. The question is the interest. The interest is always due."* I looked at my notes. The page was blank. The ink was gone. The lamp on the table—the one I had lit to write by—had gone out. I do not remember when. I do not remember why. I do not remember lighting it at all.

The Lamp

The Trow placed a finger on my page. "You wrote this," it said. "But you will not remember."

When I looked down, the ink was gone.

– *Trow's corner, hour unknown.*

24 The Soup That Was Free

Told by

Hag Morag (or so she called herself). She sat by a well, stirring a pot that had no fire under it. The soup was hot. The well was dry. The pot had been stirring itself, she said, for longer than the village had stood. She did not explain. She did not need to. A woman who sits by a dry well and stirs hot soup with no fire is not in the business of explanations.

The Tale

A starving family came to a cottage. Not their own—they had lost their own to a fire, to a tax collector, to a winter that would not end. The story varied depending on who told it. What did not vary was the hunger. The mother's ribs showed through her dress. The father's hands shook when he knocked. The children did not cry. They had forgotten how.

A crone answered the door. Her eyes were the color of old milk. Her hands were the color of bark. She wore a shawl that had been mended so many times it was more thread than cloth.

"I have soup," she said. "It is free. The first bowl is always free. That is the rule. I did not make the rule. The rule was here before me. The rule will be here after."

They ate. The soup was rich, meaty, warm—thicker than any soup they had ever tasted, darker than any broth they had ever seen. It had chunks of something soft and something chewy and something that melted on the tongue like butter. They did not ask what was in it. Hungry people do not ask. Hungry people eat.

They ate until they were full. The children's cheeks flushed. The mother's hands stopped trembling. The father sat back in his chair and sighed—a long, slow breath that seemed to leave him lighter than he had been when he arrived.

The crone watched. Her eyes did not blink. *"The soup is free," she said again. "The first bowl is free. But the seconds will cost you. The rule is clear. The bowl does not lie."*

The family hesitated. The father said, *"We have no coin. We have nothing. You can see our bones through our skin. What could we possibly have that you would want?"*

"I do not need coin," said the crone. "Coin is for merchants. I am not a merchant. I am a cook. I need a breath. One breath from each of you. Not your last breath—do not worry. I am not the Pale Shepherd. I do not take what you need to live. I take what you have to spare. Hold a breath

for me. Just one. I will give it back when you next share a meal—a meal you cook yourselves, at your own hearth, with your own hands.”

They agreed. What else could they do? They were full. They were grateful. They breathed into her kettle—one long, slow exhalation each, watching their breath fog the rim of the pot, watching the steam rise and curl and disappear into the crone’s shawl. The kettle steamed. The soup bubbled. The crone nodded.

They left. That night, they dreamed they were drowning—not in water, but in something thicker, something that tasted of salt and old meat and the memory of hunger. They woke gasping, their chests tight, their breath shorter than it had been the day before.

They returned to the cottage. The crone was stirring the same pot. The fire was still absent. The soup was still hot.

“The debt is not due yet,” she said. “The rule allows for patience. Eat again. The first bowl is still free. The second bowl will cost another breath. The third will cost two. The fourth will cost four. The rule is clear. The bowl does not lie.”

They ate. They were not hungry. The soup had filled them, and the soup had not left. It sat in their bellies like a stone, warm and heavy and patient. They ate anyway. The father ate because he was afraid. The mother ate

because she was tired. The children ate because the soup was warm and the night was cold and they had stopped asking questions.

The crone took another breath. The kettle grew heavier. The soup darkened.

For a year, they ate free soup once a week. Each time, the crone took a breath. Each time, the sleep grew deeper, the waking shorter, the dreams more vivid. They dreamed of drowning in soup. They dreamed of drowning in the kettle. They dreamed of the crone's eyes, old-milk white, watching them sink.

On the last night—the night of the forty-eighth bowl, the night when the father's breath came in rasps and the mother's steps dragged on the floor and the children slept for sixteen hours at a stretch—the father said, *"We cannot pay. We have no breath left. The rule is clear. The bowl does not lie. What happens when we have nothing left to give?"*

The crone nodded. Her eyes, for the first time, softened. *"Good,"* she said. *"Now you are honest. The honesty is the payment I was waiting for. The soup was the toll. The breaths were the interest. The honesty is the principal. Go home. Cook your own meals. Breathe your own air. Dream your own dreams. The kettle will remember you. The kettle always remembers. But it will not follow. It does not need to. You know where it lives."*

They went home. They felt lighter—not the lightness of a full belly, but the lightness of a released breath, of a held note finally sung, of a door that had been waiting to close. Their breath returned. Their sleep cleared. The dreams stopped.

They never ate free soup again. But sometimes, on winter nights, when the wind was right, they could smell it—rich and meaty and warm, drifting from the direction of the dry well. They did not follow the smell. They had learned. The soup was free. The seconds were not. The rule was clear. The bowl did not lie.

The Witch's Closing

“Free soup is a hook. The hook is not the soup. The hook is the second bowl. The third bowl. The bowl you eat when you are not hungry. The bowl you eat because you are afraid of being hungry again. The crone does not need your coin. She needs your breath. And your breath, once given, is never quite your own again.”

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Hungry Kettle

A pot that produces unlimited nourishing soup—thick, dark, warm, satisfying in ways that have nothing to do with taste. The soup fills the belly. The soup warms the bones. The soup also takes. Each bowl consumed steals a small amount of breath, a sliver of life, a thread from the tapestry of the eater’s waking hours. The soup is a loan. The interest compounds. The kettle does not lie.

Tags / Mechanics:

HEAL [CURSE] [SACRIFICE] [PRESSURE]

- The soup restores 1 Supply per bowl. It also restores 1 Fatigue—but only temporarily. The eater feels refreshed for one hour. Then the Fatigue returns, along with an additional point of Fatigue that cannot be recovered by rest. The soup cheats. The soup always cheats.
- Each bowl causes the eater to mark 1 Fatigue (which cannot be recovered by rest until the curse is lifted). This Fatigue stacks. There is no limit except the eater’s willingness to keep eating.

- **Clock: The Kettle's Patience [4]** — each bowl ticks once. When the timer fills, the eater must perform a favor for the hag (or a hag of her choosing—they know each other, they share notes, they compare debts). The favor will be strange. The favor will be difficult. The favor will not be dangerous, precisely—the hag does not need danger. She needs compliance. Refusal causes the accumulated Fatigue to become permanent. It cannot be healed by any means. It becomes part of the eater, like a scar, like a limp, like a name you cannot forget.
- The kettle can be destroyed—shattered, buried, thrown into deep water. It will reform within a year. The hag is patient. The kettle is patient. The soup is always free.

Adventure Hook: A village has been living on free soup from a mysterious old woman who appears at the edge of the woods every night. The villagers are growing weak. They sleep too much. Their breaths come in rasps. Their children dream of drowning. The party must discover the price of the soup—and whether they can break the kettle without starving the village. The hag watches from the well. The hag does not interfere. The hag does not need to. The villagers will return on their own. They always

return. The soup is free. The second bowl is not.

Colophon

Well at a crossroads. The crone winked—a slow, deliberate motion, like a lizard closing one eye. “*You did not eat,*” she said. “*That is good. I would have taken your ink. Your ink is old. Your ink has seen things. Your ink would have made the soup bitter.*” She stirred the pot. The pot was empty. It had been empty the whole time. The soup had never been there. Or perhaps the soup had always been there, and the seeing was the eating, and the eating was the debt, and the debt was the story, and the story was the soup, and the soup was free. She did not explain. She did not need to.

The Kettle

The Hag tapped the pot. It rang like a bell. "Soup is ready," she said. "You are not hungry. That is wise."

– *Crossroad well, dusk.*

